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Left Turn

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**Defining Racism: Individuals and
Institutions, Systems and Structures**

Robert Jensen

The United States Is Exceptional

Aviva Chomsky

**Navigating our Humanity:
Four Lessons from Ukraine**

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Notes from the Editor

The war in Ukraine has taken much of the attention of the media. The saturation coverage displays subservience to state power and omits many important aspects of the current crisis. This double issue of *Left Turn* features many pieces offering alternative perspectives and correcting for the media's omissions. Additionally, the media are ignoring the other ongoing war against the planet we inhabit. In this issue, Aviva Chomsky's essay deals with the looming climate catastrophe. The message of ecological crisis has as yet to make its way to the mainstream. Perhaps readers may think that it has. It has not, not in a critical way. When the media and politicians pay attention to climate emergency, they do so in a way that equates the status quo with the normal.

To convey the seriousness of the climate crisis, scientists have taken to civil disobedience. This April, Scientist Rebellion, a global movement of scientists, organized a wave of civil disobedience actions in more than 25 countries. A group of them were arrested after they chained themselves to a JPMorgan Chase building in Los Angeles to protest its financing of fossil fuels. One of them, Dr. Peter Kalmus, a NASA scientist, broke down in tears in a video pleading with people to take the issue seriously. "We're going to lose everything," he said. "And we're not joking, we're not lying, we're not exaggerating." The protests came after the release of the latest UN's Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change report on 4 April that warned the planet is "firmly on track toward an unlivable world," unless global greenhouse gas emissions peak no later than by 2025. The report "is a litany of broken climate promises," said the UN's Secretary General António Guterres. "It is a file of shame, cataloguing the empty pledges that put us firmly on track towards an unlivable world." If we cannot avoid the looming ecological catastrophe, nothing else we do matters.

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The United States Is Exceptional

Just Not in the Ways Any of Us Should Want

AVIVA CHOMSKY

Three years after the end of World War II, diplomat George Kennan outlined the challenges the country faced this way: “We have about 50% of the world’s wealth, but only 6.3% of its population. In this situation, we cannot fail to be the object of envy and resentment. Our real task in the coming period is to devise a pattern of relationships which will permit us to maintain this position of disparity without positive detriment to our national security.”

That, in a nutshell, was the postwar version of U.S. exceptionalism and Washington was then planning to manage the world in such a way as to maintain that remarkably grotesque disparity. The only obstacle Kennan saw was poor people demanding a share of the wealth.

Today, as humanity confronts a looming climate catastrophe, what’s needed is a new political-economic project. Its aim would be to replace such exceptionalism and the hoarding of the earth’s resources with what’s been called “a good life for all within planetary boundaries.”

Back in 1948, few if any here were thinking about the environmental effects of the over-consumption of available resources. Yet even then, however unknown, this country’s growing wealth had a dark underside: the slow-brewing crisis of climate change. Wealth all too literally meant the intensified extraction of resources and the production of goods. As it happened, fossil fuels (and the greenhouse gases that went with their burning) were essential to every step in the process.

Today, the situation has shifted at least a bit. With approximately 4% of the world’s population, the United States still holds about 30% of its wealth, while its commitment to over-consumption and maintaining global dominance remains remarkably unshaken. To grasp that, all you have to do is consider the Biden White House’s recent Indo-Pacific Strategy policy brief, which begins in this telling way: “The United States is an Indo-Pacific power.” Indeed.

In 2022, the relationship between wealth, emissions, and climate catastrophe has become ever clearer. In the crucial years between 1990 and 2015, the global economy expanded from \$47 trillion to \$108 trillion. During that same period, global annual greenhouse-gas emissions grew by more than 60%. Mind you, 1990 was the year in which atmospheric levels of carbon dioxide (CO₂) first surpassed what many scientists believed was the level of safety 350 parts per million, or ppm. Yet in the 32 years since then, more CO₂ and other greenhouse gases have been emitted into the atmosphere than in all of history prior to that date, as atmospheric CO₂ careened past 400 ppm in 2016 with 420 ppm now fast approaching.

Inequality and Emissions

Growing global wealth is closely associated with growing emissions. But the wealth and responsibility for those emissions are not shared equally among the planet’s population. On an individual level, the wealthiest people on Earth consume and emit far more than their poorer counterparts. The richest 10% of the world’s population, or about 630 million people, were responsible for more than half of the increase in greenhouse-gas emissions over the last quarter-century. On a national level, rich countries are, of course, home to far more people with high levels of consumption, which means that the larger and wealthier the country, the greater its emissions.

In terms of per capita income, the United States ranks 13th in the world. But the countries above it on the list are mostly tiny, including some of the Persian Gulf states, Ireland, Luxembourg, Singapore, and Switzerland. So, despite their high per-capita emissions, their overall contribution isn’t that big. As the third-largest country on this planet, our soaring per-capita emissions have, on the other hand, had a devastating effect.

With a population of around 330 million, the United States today has less than a quarter of either China’s population of more than 1.4 billion or India’s, which is just under that figure. Four other countries Brazil, Indonesia, Nigeria, and Pakistan fall into the population range of 200 to 300 million, but their per-capita gross domestic products (GDPs) and their per-capita emissions are far below ours. In fact, the total U.S. GDP of more than \$19 trillion far exceeds that of any other country, followed by China at \$12 trillion and Japan at \$5 trillion.

In sum, the United States is exceptional when it comes to both its size and wealth. I’m sure you won’t be surprised to learn then that, until 2006, it was also by far the world’s top CO₂ emitter. After that, it was surpassed by a fast-developing China (though that country’s per capita emissions remain less than half of ours) and no other country’s greenhouse gas emissions come close to either of those two.

To fully understand different countries’ responsibility, it’s necessary to go past yearly numbers and look at how much they’ve emitted over time, since the greenhouse gases we put in the atmosphere don’t disappear at the end of the year. Here again, one country stands out above all the others: the United States, whose cumulative emissions reached 416 billion tons by the end of 2020. China’s, which didn’t start rising rapidly until the 1980s, reached 235 billion tons in that year, while India trailed at 54 billion.

Having first hit 20 billion tons in 1910, U.S. cumulative emissions have only shot up ever since, while China’s didn’t hit that 20 billion mark until 1979. So, the U.S. got a big head start and, cumulatively speaking, is still way ahead when it comes to taking down this planet.

The U.S. Climate Action Network (USCAN) argues that excessive emitters like the United States have already used up far more than their “fair share” of this planet’s carbon budget and so, in fact, owe a huge carbon debt to the rest of the world to make up for their outsized contribution to the problem of climate change over the past two centuries. Unfortunately, the 2015 Paris Agreement’s voluntary, non-enforceable, and nationally determined limits on emissions functionally let rich countries continue on their damaging ways.

In fact, nations should be held responsible for repaying their carbon debt. The world's poorest people, who have contributed practically nothing to the problem, deserve access to a portion of the remaining budget and to the sort of aid that would enable them to develop alternative forms of energy to meet their basic needs.

Under the fair-share proposal, it's not enough for the United States just to stop adding emissions. This country needs to repay the climate debt it's already incurred. USCAN calculates that to pay back its fair share the United States must cut its emissions by 70% by 2030, while contributing the cash equivalent of another 125% of its current emissions every year through technical and financial support to energy-poor nations.

Bernie Sanders's Green New Deal proposal adopted the concept of the "fair share." True leadership in the global climate fight, Sanders has argued, means recognizing that "the United States has for over a century spewed carbon pollution emissions into the atmosphere in order to gain economic standing in the world. Therefore, we have an outsized obligation to help less industrialized nations meet their targets while improving quality of life."

On this subject, however, his voice and others like it sadly remain far outside the all-too-right-wing mainstream. (And if you doubt that, just check Joe Manchin's recent voting record.)

Are We Making Progress Thanks to New Technologies?

In 2018, the U.N.'s Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) issued a special report on our chances of limiting global warming to 1.5 degrees centigrade the goal that the countries involved in the Paris Agreement, including the United States, accepted as their baseline for action. It concluded that, to have a 50% chance of staying below that temperature increase, our future collective emissions couldn't exceed 480 gigatons (or 480 billion tons). That, in other words, was humanity's remaining carbon budget.

Unfortunately, as of 2018, global emissions were exceeding 40 gigatons a year, which meant that even if they were flattened almost immediately (not exactly a likelihood), we would use up that budget in a mere dozen years or so. Worse yet, despite a Covid-induced decline in 2020, global emissions actually rebounded sharply in 2021.

Most scenarios for emission reductions, including those proposed by the IPCC, rely optimistically on new technologies to enable us to get there without making substantive changes in the global economy or in the excessive consumption of the world's richest people and countries. Such technological advances, it's hoped, would allow us to produce as much, or possibly more energy from renewable sources and even possibly begin removing CO₂ from the atmosphere.

Unfortunately, there's little evidence to support the likelihood of such progress, especially in the time we have left. No matter how much new technology we develop, there seems to be no completely "clean" form of energy. All of them nuclear, wind, solar, hydropower, geothermal, biomass, and perhaps others still to be developed rely on massive industrial operations to extract finite resources from the earth; factories to process them; facilities to create, store, and transmit energy; and, in the end, some form of waste (think batteries, solar panels, old electric cars, and so on). Every form of

energy will have multiple dangerous environmental impacts. Meanwhile, as the use of alternative forms of energy production increases worldwide, it hasn't yet reduced fossil-fuel use. Instead, it's just added to our growing energy consumption.

It's true that the world's wealthiest countries have achieved some gains in decoupling economic growth from rising emissions. But much of this relatively minor decoupling is attributable to a shift from the use of coal to natural gas, along with the outsourcing of particularly dirty industries. Decoupling has, as yet, made no dent in global greenhouse gas emissions and seems unlikely to accelerate or even continue at a meaningful enough pace after these first and easiest steps have been taken. So almost all climate modeling, like that of the IPCC, suggests that new technologies to remove CO₂ from the atmosphere will also be needed to counter rising emissions.

But negative emissions technologies are largely aspirational at this point. Instead of counting on what still to a significant extent remain technological fantasies, while the wealthy continue their profligacy, it's time to shift our thinking more radically and focus, as I do in my new book *Is Science Enough? Forty Critical Questions About Climate Justice*, on how to reduce extraction, production, and consumption in far more socially just ways, so that we can indeed begin to live within our planet's means. Call it "post-growth" or "degrowth" thinking.

Make no mistake: we can't live without energy and we desperately do need to turn to alternatives to fossil fuels. But alternative energies are only going to be truly viable if we can also greatly reduce our energy needs, which means reconfiguring the global economy. If energy is a scarce and precious resource, then ways must be found to prioritize its use to meet the urgent needs of the world's poor, rather than endlessly expanding the luxuries of the wealthiest among us. And that's precisely what degrowth thinking is all about: scaling back the mindless pursuit of production, consumption, and profit in favor of "human wellbeing and ecological stability."

Abandoning Exceptionalism

In April 2021, President Biden made a dramatic announcement, setting a new goal for U.S. greenhouse-gas emissions to reduce them by 50% from 2005 levels by 2030 and reach net-zero by 2050. Sounds pretty good, right?

But given that this country's CO₂ emissions had hit a high of 6.13 billion tons in 2005, that means by 2030 we'd still be emitting three billion tons of CO₂ a year. Even if we could reach net-zero by 2050, our country alone would, by then, have used up one-quarter of the entire remaining carbon budget for the planet. And right now, given the state of the American political system, there's neither a genuine plan nor an obvious way to reach Biden's goal. If we stay on our current path and don't count on that if the Republicans take Congress in 2022 and the White House again in 2024 we would barely achieve a 30% reduction by 2030.

At this point, there's no guarantee we'll stay on that path, no matter the political party in power. After all, consider just this: In 2010, about half of the new vehicles sold in the United States were cars and half were SUVs or trucks. By 2021, close to 80% were SUVs or trucks.

In 2020, more than 900,000 new houses were built in this country, their median size, 2,261 square feet. Most of them had four or more bedrooms and 870,000 had central air conditioning.

President Biden's infrastructure bill, signed in November 2021, included \$763 billion for new highways.

And let's not even talk about the military-industrial-congressional complex and war. After all, the Department of Defense is the single largest institutional consumer of fossil fuels and emitter of CO₂ in the world. Between its worldwide bases, promotion of the arms industry, and ongoing global wars, our military alone produces annual emissions greater than those of wealthy countries like Sweden and Denmark.

Meanwhile, in the run-up to the climate-change meeting in Glasgow, Scotland, in the fall of 2021, Special Presidential Envoy for Climate John Kerry insisted repeatedly that the United States must work to bring China on board. Joe Biden too kept his attention focused on China. And indeed, given its greenhouse gas emissions and still-expanding use of coal, China does have a big role to play. But to the rest of the world, such an insistence on diverting attention from our own role in the climate crisis rings hollow indeed.

A 2021 study shows that almost all of the world's remaining coal, not to speak of most of its gas and oil reserves, will need to stay in the ground if global warming is to be kept below 1.5 degrees centigrade. Back in 2018, another study found that even to meet a 2-degree centigrade goal, which it's now all too clear would be catastrophic in climate-change terms, humanity would have to halt all new fossil-fuel-based infrastructure and immediately start decommissioning fossil-fuel-burning plants. Instead, such new facilities continue to be built in a relentless fashion globally. Unless the United States, which bears by far the greatest responsibility for our climate emergency, is ready to radically change course, how can it demand that others do so?

But to change course would mean to abandon exceptionalism.

Degrowth scholars argue that, rather than risking all of our futures on as-yet-unproven technologies in order to cling to economic growth, we should seek social and political solutions that would involve redistributing the planet's wealth, its scarce resources, and its carbon budget in ways that prioritize basic needs and social well-being globally.

That, however, would require the United States to acknowledge the dark side of its exceptionalism and agree to relinquish it, something that, in March 2022, still seems highly unlikely.

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Is Asia Possible?

Two words mean so little these days—Asia and solidarity.

VIJAY PRASHAD



Image courtesy 7 Continents

Asia now refers merely to geography, to the vast terrain from one end of Japan to the other end of Lebanon that stretches across the globe, looking almost as if it will tear into bits from the tension.

Even the geography is unclear. Russia is the country with the largest landmass in Asia; it is almost twice the size of China. Yet, there is little consciousness of Russia as being part of Asia. It is typically seen as a European country or—at best—as a Eurasian state. Perhaps as Russia gets closer to China, it will turn its eyes from Berlin and Paris and look towards Beijing and Delhi with a little more clarity about its own future. Large parts of West Asia—from Palestine to the border of Afghanistan—are generally thought of as the Middle East and not as part of Asia (this applies to the Arabian Peninsula). The Himalayas rise like massive walls and have—over the centuries—blocked the easy traffic of ideas and customs between India and China. Buddhism had to travel through Afghanistan and then turn right to head into China and Japan. It could not easily cross the mountains.

Some countries—like India—are a continent themselves, hundreds of languages, thousands of cultural worlds. Other countries—like Indonesia—are broken up by hundreds of islands that are separated by over 5000 kilometers from one end to another. The highest point on the earth is in Asia (Mount Everest) and the lowest point on the earth is in Asia (the Dead Sea). The old Mongols would have ridden along the steppe for four thousand kilometers, going from the Uvs Nur basin to the Don River, passing all kinds of people, speaking all kinds of languages, growing all kinds of crops, nurturing all kinds of dreams of the afterlife and the purpose of life.

It is impossible to imagine 'Asia' as a simple word, a word that refers to something definitive. There are a hundred etymologies of the word 'Asia', most of them going to the ancient Greeks or even the Goths. None of these stories come from within the continent itself. There is an Assyrian wooden slab (a stele) which calls the western side of Assyria (Ereb) the 'country of sunset' and the eastern side of Assyria (Asu) the country of 'sunrise'. This is a mere obvious fact for the Assyrian people, where the sun rises and sets, and not a real definition of the continent and its name.

Each of our continents in the Global South are devised in the majestic world of colonial science. They are not entities with a deep endogamous history.

Every place is a construct. No place is natural, even if it is island. If an island were a naturally bounded country, what to make of an archipelago (such as Indonesia with 17,504 islands) or what to make of an island divided into two countries (such as Hispaniola divided into the Dominican Republic and Haiti)? No boundary is natural, no nation is rooted in anything other than human history and human politics. That is a lesson being learned every time a new war breaks out, terrible wars in the Horn of Africa or in the steppe of Ukraine.

Which is why we seek the meaning of Asia not in ancient times, in a Greek word, but in its modern history, when it became clear that the people of this vast area were prepared to find political unity for a definitive use. When was this unity necessary? It was necessary as a means to confront imperialism, the extra-economic force used largely by the advanced industrial states of their age (Great Britain and the United States) to subordinate the land and the labor of the people who lived on this grand, vast landmass. It was in this struggle against imperialism that 'India' was born, that 'China' was born, that 'Indonesia' was born, that the 'Philippines' was born. Nationalist historians and politicians turn backwards, seeking to legitimize their national stories in the ancient world. But these are fabrications. They are necessary to make people feel like their patriotism and their nationalism is old, when in fact it is not so old, not so natural, not so rooted in antiquity and race. For the people inside this vast landmass, nations were born in struggle against an oppressor, against an invader. It was the invader who partly helped shape the conditions for the creation of the nation. The people themselves, in their anti-colonial struggles, reached backward to their history and their geography to design the actual shape of their nationalism — sometime a nationalism rooted in the patriotism of the poor, but often a nationalism soured by the ugliness of profit for the few.

And so too the idea of 'Asia' or — more properly — pan-Asia. This was the cognate of pan-Africanism and pan-Arabism, of Patria Grande in Latin America — ideas of political unity for a people who had been subjugated by imperialism. There was no pan-Africanism that predated the fight against colonialism, no Patria Grande without the anti-imperialist sensibility, no pan-Arabism without the deep humiliation of colonial domination. The desire for continental and global unity came from the deep longing to defeat imperialism. This is why people came from far and wide to Moscow to attend the meetings of the Communist International from 1919 — and especially from 1920 onwards as far as Asian delegates were concerned — and it is why so many Asian radicals and nationalists came to Brussels in 1927-28 for the League Against Imperialism meeting. It was clear that the Great War of 1914-1918 and the Revolu-

tion in the Tsarist Empire that produced the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics had dented the invincibility of the imperialists. It was equally clear that the tepid promises of independence made by the League of Nations would not be honored and that matters had to be taken in hand.

That was the sensibility at the first Pan-African conference of 1919 held in Paris. It was the sensibility of Sharif Hussein, who took on the name King of the Arab Countries in 1916 and called for the freedom and unity of the Arab lands. It was this emotion that led Manuel Ugarte, an Argentinian, to write the 1922 book *La Patria Grande*, a call for the unification of the Spanish-speaking lands of the Americas against imperialism. It was this same spirit that animated China's Sun Yat-Sen to call for 'Greater Asianism' in a famous speech from 1924. What was the reason for the call towards Greater Asianism or Pan-Asianism? 'We advocate Pan-Asianism in order to restore the status of Asia', said Sun Yat-Sen. It was precisely the motivations of all projects for unity in the colonized world, whether in Africa, Asia or Latin America. They wished to 'restore the status' of their fallen lands.

Every project of unity in the colonized world had a continuous history — pan-Africanism continues till this day, as does Patria Grande, as does pan-Arabism. The dents and scuffs of internal tensions prevent the realization of any of these concepts, but the very ideas remain intact. Pan-Asianism is different. The idea burned to a crisp because of Japanese expansionism, with its Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere and its use of the concepts of Asian unity for its domination of large parts of Asia. In 1943, the Greater East Asia Conference in Tokyo brought together heads of states of various effectively colonies of Japan, where the Japanese Prime Minister Hideki Tojo praised the 'spiritual essence' of Asia. Tojo used the same kind of emotional and romantic language that had marked the world of people such as the Japanese art historian Kakuzo Okakura and the Indian poet Rabindranath Tagore. Okakura had lived in Tagore's Calcutta house for almost a year in 1902. It was here that Okakura wrote *The Awakening of Asia* (1904) and it was here that he began *The Ideals of the East* (1903). 'Asia is one', begins *The Ideals*. All this was charming. But, then, in *The Awakening of Japan* (1904), Okakura supported his country's annexation of Korea (Japan, he wrote, had no ambitions over Korea or Manchuria. 'If China and Russia had respected the independence of Korea, no wars would have taken place' — this is a fanciful interpretation). It is in this book that Okakura bemoans the reputation of Japan — 'so eager to identify ourselves with European civilization instead of Asiatic that our continental neighbors regard us as renegades — nay, even as an embodiment of the White Disaster itself'.

Tagore tired of the 'White Disaster', of imperialism disguised as something high-minded — the donation of Western Civilization or Japanese Culture. When he visited Japan in 1916, Tagore gave a stinging rebuke to nationalism, which was really to the kind of expansionary behavior of the Japanese empire. Accused of being soft, Tagore wrote a poem 'The Song of the Defeated'.

*My master has bid me while I stand at the roadside
To sing the song of defeat
For that is the bride whom he woos in secret
She has put on the dark veil, hiding her face from the crowd
But the jewel glows on her breast in the dark.*

Tagore gave the poem to a Korean student—Chin Hak-Mun—who was studying in Japan. Chin Hak-Mun, who would later become a well-known writer, visited Tagore at the Yokohama home of the art collector and banker Hara Tomitaro. Tagore's gift suggested another kind of pan-Asianism, a unity of the defeated who hoped one day to overcome defeat not with empires of their own but with something more precious than that—solidarity amongst peoples for the mutual well-being of each and all. It is not defeat that is shameful, suggested Tagore, but subordination of others.

In 1917, Tagore published *Nationalism*, in which he wrote, 'nationalism is a great menace'. What he meant was that the European form—rooted in the illusion of social cohesion and of industrial progress—would leave countries such as Japan and India struggling with the 'borrowed weapons of civilization' and unwilling to harness their own inheritance. Political independence was necessary, settling accounts with the wretchedness of social hierarchy was necessary, but so too was a generous attitude to one's own past and to what one might learn from one's neighbors. India, Tagore suggested, needed to surmount the challenges of caste hierarchy (as the United States needed to deal with its ugly racism, he pointed out); but then India and other Asian countries should not turn inward, but need to learn from each other to advance the project of human development.

After World War II ended, the dream of pan-Asianism remained gently intact. The Asian Relations Conference of 1947 opened with India's Nehru calling for a new project, something miles away from the Japanese empire. 'We have no designs against anybody', Nehru said, 'Ours is the great design of promoting peace and progress all over the world'. Japanese delegates—eager for a fresh start—wanted to come to the Asian Relations Conference in 1947 but were prevented by the US Occupation authorities. There is a straight line that goes from the Asian Relations Conference to the Asian-African Conference of 1955 at Bandung and to the formation of the Non-Aligned Movement in Belgrade in 1961. Calls for an Asian Federation in 1947 were rebuffed by South-East Asians who had just come out of the terrible experience of Japanese expansionism, and they were set aside by the countries around Asia that had joined one or more of the other US military alliances (CENTO and SEATO). The vicious wars by the new imperialist powers against Korea and Vietnam, Malaya and Indonesia set the dial for Asian unity at zero. British concentration camps for the communist insurgents and US carpet bombing of the Korean north sent a strong message across Asia for the old notables and the new bourgeois nationalists to hide under the umbrella of Western power against their own people. Border conflicts between India and China and between Pakistan and India as well as across South-East Asia made dreams of unity appear distant.

In this context, to think of 'Asia' was an illusion. While Kwame Nkrumah championed pan-Africanism and Gamal Abdul Nasser pushed pan-Arabism, no political force in Asia could legitimately drive a pan-Asian agenda. There simply is no intellectual or political resource generated during the Cold War that developed a progressive pan-Asian platform.

The tentacles of US imperialism and the malignancies of the Cold War undermined any possibility of a renewed pan-Asianism. The hub and spokes system of US power encircled the USSR and China, reducing countries such as Japan and the

Philippines, Pakistan and Iran into military bases, dependencies with their own flags, paranoid old notables carrying buckets for the White Disaster, as Okakura called it. What could have flourished after Bandung faltered, border wars and trade wars engulfed the energy for unity and progress. The clarity of Kwame Nkrumah did not make itself felt on the Asian continent—Nkrumah warning, five decades ago, 'If we do not formulate plans for unity and take active steps to form political union, we will soon be fighting and warring among ourselves with the imperialists and colonialists standing behind the screen and pulling vicious wires to make us cut each other's throats for the sake of their diabolical purposes in Africa'. There is no such ideological seam in Asia, no such political direction that puts at the forefront the importance of unity against division.

Nostalgic returns to Asian spiritualism, crafted by the Singaporean intellectual Kishore Mahbubhani and championed by Singapore's Lee Kwan Yew and Malaysia's Mahathir Mohamad in the 1990s, stressed Asian cultural superiority as a way to explain the rise of the Tigers. This was a facile theory, absent any real economic content, that sought an explanation for the global commodity chain in Asian values. The locus was East Asia, bewilderment being the sense in the literature about South, Central, West and North Asia. For in India half the population lives in poverty—over 700 million people. No cultural explanation is sufficient for its condition. This sentiment—Asian values—was merely a description of why the Tigers flourished not a hope for Asian unity. In fact, Asian unity was not on the cards at all.

Hard-nosed pragmatic policies have emerged to unite certain countries in Asia. The fragility of US hegemony after the illegal war on Iraq and the world financial crisis brought to the forefront the BRICS project, a platform to claim multipolarity as the unipolar system fell apart. But this BRICS dynamic now flounders as right-wing authoritarian and neo-fascist governments hold power in at least Brazil and India. The BRICS project was never continental or even regional. It was always a place for regional giants—South Africa for the Africa continent, Brazil for South America—to link up with each other, challenge the unipolar order and strengthen their own role in their neighborhoods. The increased tensions around Ukraine have now revived the possibility of the BRICS playing some kind of role in the world.

Old Cold War fantasies of encaging China provide other platforms for unity—such as between India, Singapore and Japan (with India and Japan along with Australia and US as part of the Quad). But these are ugly platforms, alliances thrust upon states that are the hubs for a faltering US hegemony over Asia. Even relatively small-scale unities—the halting negotiations on the Korean peninsula—are forbidden to this kind of process. Japan and South Korea must remain client states of the West, aircraft carriers for its necessary encirclement of China's return to the world stage. No 'Asia' is possible here, only poverty and war.

In 2018, the US government announced that its War on Terror was over and that it would focus attention against its two main adversaries, China and Russia, the 'near peer' contestants for power. That faltering US hegemony comes as China stretches out of its borders through a Belt and Road Initiative and a String of Pearls strategy. Even this is limited, with China—and perhaps Russia—moving a strategic and economic agenda out of a position of defensiveness. China's development agenda

had been yoked to the US economy, and now it seeks hastily to pivot away from consumers who are over-leveraged to new consumers in Central and West Asia, in South Asia and South America and across the African continent. There is no Asianism here, no progressive content beyond the importance of using social wealth to undermine starvation and deprivation.

There is a need to travel deep into our histories, to recover older dreams of Asia that spluttered into world history a hundred years ago. It would be useful to track the journey of Raja Mahendra Pratap Singh, the Marxist who went from Lenin's study (1919) to the Pan-Asiatic League Conference in Nagasaki (1926). It would be useful to look at the journeys of Ho Chi Minh, MN Roy and Tan Malaka as well as Ayna Sultanova and Nadzhiya Hanum. It would be of interest to study the writings of Hotsumi Ozaki, who oscillated between communism and nationalism, and to study the writings of An Chung-gun, the Korean nationalist who assassinated Prince Ito Hirobumi and paid for it with his life. It is worthwhile to start again backwards with the socialist and anarchist Asiatic Humanitarian Brotherhood (1907) and the Ajia Gikai (Asian Congress), 'an Oriental Association in Tokyo', said a British intelligence report, 'attended by Japanese, Filipinos, Siamese, Indians, Koreans and Chinese' (1909).

It would be good to breathe in our limitations, the disavowal of the Rohingya, the lack of a new economic vision for the poor, the terrible violence in the Philippines, the rigidities across the Himalayas, the impossible tensions in the South-China Sea and in the Indian Ocean, the old toxic competitiveness that has leaked into our world without any answers to the fundamental problems of our times. It would be good for artists and intellectuals to open a serious conversation about a new progressive pan-Asianism, a continental vision of a new kind of socialist world that looks beyond greed and towards the wider palate of human experience and emotion. If there is to be an Asia and if there is to be solidarity, let these words have some meaning.

Faiz Ahmed Faiz, Urdu's greatest poet, watched the defeat of the Palestinians in June 1967 and then wrote Atop the Sinai Valley (Sar-e Vaadi-e Seena),

"Once more, lightening shimmers atop the Sinai valley.
O seeing eye
Ask the hearts to line up again
That between you and I, a new promise may descend
For now, the earth's elite has decreed Tyranny to be normal
And the mufti has said oppression is worth obeying
To break this centuries-old cycle of acquiescence
A new proclamation must descend, the proclamation of dissent."

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US Policy Toward Russia Is Blocking Paths to De-escalation in Ukraine

C. J. POLYCHRONIOU INTERVIEWS NOAM CHOMSKY

C. J. Polychroniou: The war in Ukraine has turned Russia into a pariah state throughout Europe and North America, but Moscow continues to receive support from many countries in the Global South. The strategic relationship between Russia and China seems to be getting stronger, although both countries had identified each other as major factors for maintaining order and stability in an "emerging polycentric world" long before Putin and Xi Jinping. In fact, Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov said following a recent meeting with his Chinese counterpart that the two countries are working together to advance a vision of a new world order, a new "democratic world order." Is the new world order one that pits Global North and Global South countries against each other? And what do you make of the statement of Russia and China working together to promote a new "democratic world order?" To me, the idea of two autocratic states working together to promote democracy across the world sounds like a crude joke.

Noam Chomsky: The idea that Russia and China will be working together to promote a "democratic world order" is, of course, ludicrous. They will be doing so in much the way that the U.S. was laboring to "promote democracy" in Iraq, the goal of the invasion as President Bush announced when it became clear that the "single question" will Saddam abandon his nuclear weapons program? had been answered the wrong way. With rare exceptions, the intellectual class and even most scholarship leaped to attention and vigorously proclaimed the new doctrine, as I suppose is also the case today in Russia and China.

As U.S.-run polls showed, Americans enthralled by the "noble" goals belatedly proclaimed were even joined by some Iraqis: 1 percent of those polled. Four percent thought the U.S. invaded in order to help Iraqis. The rest concluded that if Iraq's exports had been asparagus and pickles, and the center of global petroleum production was in the South Pacific, the U.S. wouldn't have invaded.

I don't pretend to have any expert knowledge, but from my own experience in past weeks with the Global South press, many interviews and meetings, much personal discussion it doesn't seem to me quite accurate to say that it is supporting Moscow, except in the sense that Moscow is getting support from the Western powers that keep paying it for petroleum products and food (probably by now the source of Russia's main export earnings).

My impression is that the Global South has sharply condemned the Russian invasion, but has asked: "What's new?" The general reaction to President Biden's harsh condemnation of Putin as a war criminal seems to be something like this: It takes one to know one. We agree that he is a war criminal, and as creatures of the Enlightenment, we adopt the Kantian principle of universality that is dismissed with contempt by the West, sometimes with angry charges of whataboutism.

It is, after all, not easy for people in the civilized world increasingly, the Global South to be impressed by the "moral outrage" of Western intellectuals who just a

few years ago, when all the horrific facts were in, were enthusiastically applauding the success of the invasion of Iraq, spouting pieties about noble intentions that would have embarrassed the most abject apparatchik. And we can just imagine the reaction when they read the pious invocation of the Nuremberg judgment by the editors of *The New York Times*, who are just now coming to recognize that, “To initiate a war of aggression, therefore, is not only an international crime: it is the supreme international crime, differing only from other war crimes in that it contains within itself the accumulated evil of the whole.” The accumulated evil includes the instigation of ethnic conflict that has torn apart not only Iraq but the whole region, the horrors of ISIS, and much more.

Not, of course, what the editors have in mind. The supreme international crimes that they have supported for 60 years somehow escaped the Nuremberg judgment.

While there is appreciation in the Global South for the fact that at long last Western intellectuals and the political class are coming to perceive that aggressors can commit hideous crimes, they seem to feel that it is perhaps a little late, and curiously skewed, as they know from ample experience. They are also able to perceive that Westerners consumed with moral outrage over the crimes of enemies are still able to maintain their usual silence while their own leaders carry out terrible crimes right now in Afghanistan, Yemen, Palestine, Western Sahara, and all too many other places where they could act at once, and expeditiously, to mitigate or end these crimes.

Let’s turn to the “strategic relationship between Russia and China.” It does indeed seem to be strengthening, though it is not much of a partnership. The corrupt Russian kleptocracy can provide raw materials and advanced weapons to the economic system that Beijing is systematically establishing through mainland Asia, reaching also to Africa and the Middle East, and by now even to U.S. domains in Latin America. But not much more. Russia’s role in this highly unequal relationship is, I think, likely to diminish further, much as Europe’s international role is likely to diminish after Putin has handed Europe on a golden platter to the U.S.-run “Atlanticist” system, a gift of substantial significance, as we’ve discussed before.

CJP: Can China help end the war in Ukraine? If yes, what’s stopping Beijing from using its influence over Moscow for a peace agreement to be reached in Ukraine?

NC: China could act to advance the prospects for a peaceful negotiated settlement in Ukraine. It seems that the Chinese leadership sees no advantage in doing so.

China’s “information system” appears to be pretty much conforming to the Russian propaganda line. But more generally, it doesn’t seem to diverge much from a fairly common stance in the Global South, illustrated graphically by the sanctions map. The states joining in sanctions against Russia are in the Anglosphere and Europe, as well as Japan, Taiwan and South Korea. The rest of the world condemns the invasion, but is mostly standing aloof.

This should not surprise us. It is nothing new. We recall well that the Iraq invasion had virtually no global support. Less familiar is the fact that the same was true of the U.S. invasion of Afghanistan after 9/11. A few weeks after the invasion, an international Gallup poll asked the question: “Once the identity of the [9/11] terrorists is known, should the American government launch a military attack on the country or countries where the terrorists are based or should the American government seek to extradite the terrorists to stand trial?”

The wording reflects the fact that their identity was not known. Even eight months later, in his first major press conference, FBI Director Robert Mueller could only affirm that al-Qaeda was suspected of the crime. If the poll had asked about actual U.S. policy, the very limited support would doubtless have been even lower.

World opinion overwhelmingly favored diplomatic-judicial measures over military action. Opposition to invasion was particularly strong in Latin America, which has a little experience with U.S. intervention.

The free press spared Americans knowledge of international opinion. It was therefore able to proclaim that “the opposition [to the U.S. invasion] was mostly limited to the people who are reflexively against the American use of power.”

Quite a few suffer from this malady, apparently. Global opinion today should come as no great surprise.

China’s unwillingness to devote its efforts to a negotiated settlement of the Ukraine conflict deserves criticism, but it is hard to see how such criticism can properly come from Americans. After all, China is adhering to official U.S. policy. Simply put, the policy is to “fight to the last Ukrainian for Ukrainian independence” while offering no way to save Ukraine from further tragedy. Even worse, current policy undermines such hopes by informing Putin that he has no way out: It’s The Hague or proceed to destroy Ukraine.

The quote and the opinions just paraphrased are those of one of the most astute and widely respected U.S. diplomats, Ambassador Chas Freeman, who goes on to spell out the options, and to remind us of the history.

Like anyone who cares in the least about the fate of Ukrainians, Ambassador Freeman recognizes that the only alternative to Russian destruction of Ukraine which, with their backs to the wall, Putin and his narrow circle of siloviki can implement is a negotiated settlement that will be ugly, offering the aggressors an escape. He also carries the history back further than we have done in our earlier discussions, back to the Congress of Vienna of 1814, which followed the Napoleonic Wars. Metternich and other European leaders, he observes, “had the good sense to reincorporate [defeated] France into the governing councils of Europe,” overlooking its virtual conquest of Europe. That led to a century of substantial peace in Europe, which had long been the most violent part of the world. There were some wars, but nothing like what preceded. The century of peace ended with World War I.

Freeman goes on to remind us that the victors in the war did not have the good sense of their predecessors: “The victors—the United States and Britain and France insisted on excluding Germany from a role in the affairs of Europe, as well as this newly formed Soviet Union, the result was World War II and the Cold War.”

As we’ve discussed earlier, a leading theme throughout the Cold War was the status of Europe: Should it subordinate itself to the U.S. within the Atlanticist-NATO framework, the U.S. preference? Or should it become an independent “third force” along Gaullist lines, accommodating Russia within a Europe without military alliances from the Atlantic to the Urals?

The question arose starkly when the USSR collapsed, and Mikhail Gorbachev outlined the vision of a “common European home” with no military alliances from Lisbon to Vladivostok. In a limited form, the concept was revived by French President Emmanuel Macron in his recent abortive interchanges with Putin.

If there had been anyone in the Kremlin who resembled a statesman, they would have leaped at the opportunity to explore something like the Gorbachev vision. Europe has strong reasons to establish close relations with Russia, ranging from commerce to security. Whether such efforts might have succeeded, avoiding the Ukraine tragedy, we can only guess. The answer could only have been found out by trying. Instead, the hard men in Moscow turned to violence, compounding their criminal aggression with self-defeating foolishness.

The Gorbachev conception had some partial U.S. support within the framework of the Partnership for Peace, a U.S. initiative intended to provide a cooperative security system with a limited relation to NATO. Ambassador Freeman, who had a significant role in establishing it, describes its fate in words that are worth heeding: “What happened in 1994, which was a midterm election year, and 1996, which was a presidential election year, was interesting. In 1994, Mr. Clinton was talking out of both sides of his mouth. He was telling the Russians that we were in no rush to add members to NATO, and that our preferred path was the Partnership for Peace. The same time he was hinting to the ethnic diasporas of Russophobic countries in Eastern Europe and, by the way, it’s easy to understand their Russophobia given their history that, no, no, we were going to get these countries into NATO as fast as possible. And in 1996 he made that pledge explicit. [In] 1994 he got an outburst from [Boris] Yeltsin, who was then the president of the Russian Federation. [In] 1996 he got another one, and as time went on, when Mr. Putin came in, he regularly protested the enlargement of NATO in ways that disregarded Russia’s self-defense interests. So, there should have been no surprise about this. For 28 years Russia has been warning that at some point it would snap, and it has, and it has done it in a very destructive way, both in terms of its own interests and in terms of the broader prospects for peace in Europe.”

None of this provides any excuse for Putin’s invasion, Freeman emphasizes. But it is important to understand that, “There were those people in the United States who were triumphalist about the end of the Cold War.... This allowed the United States to incorporate all the countries right up to Russia’s borders and beyond them, beyond those borders in the Baltics, into an American sphere of influence. And, essentially, they posited a global sphere of influence for the United States modeled on the Monroe Doctrine. And that’s pretty much what we have.”

Russian leadership tolerated Clinton’s violation of the firm U.S. commitment to Gorbachev not to extend NATO beyond East Germany. They even tolerated George W. Bush’s further provocations, and U.S. military actions that struck directly at Russian interests, undertaken in such a way as to humiliate Russia. But Ukraine and Georgia were red lines. That was clearly understood in Washington. As Freeman continues, no Russian leader was likely to tolerate the NATO expansion into Ukraine that began after the 2014 “coup, [carried out] to prevent neutrality or a pro-Russian government in Kiev, and to replace it with a pro-American government that would bring Ukraine into our sphere.... So, since about 2015 the United States has been arming, training Ukrainians against Russia,” effectively treating Ukraine “as an extension of NATO.”

As we’ve discussed, that stance became explicit policy in Biden’s September 2021 official statement, possibly a factor in Russia’s decision to escalate to direct aggression a few months later.

Crucially, to repeat, current U.S. policy is to “fight to the last Ukrainian” while offering no way to save Ukraine from further tragedy and in fact undermining such hopes by informing Putin that he has no way out: It’s The Hague or proceed to destroy Ukraine.

China is probably relatively satisfied with the course of events. Very likely the same is true in Washington. Both have gained from the tragedy. And the euphoria among weapons and fossil fuel producers is unconcealed as they lead the way toward indescribable catastrophe, underscored in vivid terms by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change report of April 4.

CJP: Turkey’s position over the war in Ukraine is to maintain neutrality while acting as a mediator in the Russian-Ukrainian crisis. Can Turkey continue to maintain such a balancing act since we know that it has been supplying military assistance to Ukraine since 2019 and that it is aligned with the geo-strategic vision of Washington over Ukraine?

NC: Turkey has had an ambiguous position in global affairs for many years. It is a member of NATO, but the EU has rejected its appeals for membership on human rights grounds. In the 1990s, Turkey was indeed responsible for hideous crimes: its massive state terror against its Kurdish population, leaving tens of thousands dead, 3,500 towns and villages destroyed, a flood of hundreds of thousands of people from the devastated Kurdish regions to miserable slums in Istanbul. The crimes were mostly concealed by the “free press,” perhaps because Clinton was pouring arms into Turkey, the flow escalating as atrocities mounted. Turkey became the leading recipient of U.S. military aid (apart from Israel-Egypt, a separate category), extending a very close correlation between human rights abuses and U.S. aid that goes far back, but somehow does not detract from its much-lauded nobility.

By 2000, Turkish state crimes were abating, and in the following years the situation greatly improved something I was able to witness personally, with much appreciation. By 2005, under President Recep Erdoğan’s increasingly harsh rule, the progress ended and reversed. That might have been in part a reaction to the continued refusal of the European Union to accept Turkish membership, ignoring the great steps forward in recent years and fortifying the sense that Europeans simply won’t accept Turks into their club.

Since then, Erdoğan’s rule has become far more brutal, again targeting Kurds but also attacking civil and human rights on a broad front. And he has been trying to turn Turkey into a major actor in regional affairs, with hints of a renewed Ottoman caliphate. He accepts Russian weapons over strong U.S. objections but remains a central part of the NATO system of regional by now global dominance. The “balancing act” with regard to Ukraine is a case in point.

If Turkey can facilitate negotiations that will bring the Ukraine horrors to an end, that will be a most welcome development, to be applauded. We can only speculate about what the chances are while the U.S. insists on perpetuating the conflict “to the last Ukrainian” while blocking an ugly negotiated settlement that is the alternative to destruction of Ukraine and perhaps even nuclear war.

CJP: Russian gas continues to flow to Europe although Putin had demanded that European governments pay for it in rubles. What would be the impact in the geo-strategic relations between Europe and Russia if the former became independent from Russian gas?

NC: It doesn't look likely in the near future. Europe could manage to end the use of Russian coal and oil, but gas is a different matter. That requires pipelines, which it would take years to build, or transport facilities for liquified natural gas that barely exist. But the question we should be asking I think is different. Can we ascend to the wisdom of the reactionary tyrants who provided Europe with a century of peace in Vienna in 1814? Can we move towards the Gorbachev vision of a European common home with no military alliances, a conception not too far from the U.S.-initiated Partnership for Peace that was undermined by President Clinton? Can some resemblance to statesmanship appear in today's Russia? Such questions as these should, I think, be in the forefront of our thinking, and our active engagement in trying to influence discussion and debate, and policy choices.

CJP: Evidence of Russian war crimes is mounting. Can Putin be prosecuted for war crimes in Ukraine?

NC: Prosecution for war crimes, in the real world, is "victor's justice." That was clear from the Nuremberg Tribunal and was not even concealed in the accompanying Tokyo Tribunal. At Nuremberg, saturation bombing of densely settled urban areas was excluded because it was a specialty of the Allies. German war criminals were exculpated if they could show that the Allies carried out the same crimes. In subsequent years, the Nuremberg principles were thrown out the window. They have only recently been discovered as a cudgel to beat official enemies.

There can be no thought of trying the U.S. for its many horrendous crimes. An effort was once made to bring the U.S. to justice for its war against Nicaragua. The U.S. responded to the International Court of Justice orders to end the crimes by sharply escalating them while the press dismissed the court as a "hostile forum" as shown by its daring to convict the U.S. (per The New York Times's editors), following ample precedent.

Putin might be tried for crimes if he is overthrown within Russia and Russia can be treated as a defeated country. That is what the record indicates.

Imaginably, the world might rise to a level of civilization in which international law can be honored instead of righteously wielded against selected targets. We should never cease efforts to bring that about. In doing so, we should not succumb to the illusions fostered by the global doctrinal systems.

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Another View on the US and Ukraine

GARY OLSON

Questioning the official narrative invites neo-McCarthyite slurs ranging from Putin pawn and Kremlin apologist to Russian appeaser and even, traitor. However, I've always spoken my mind and will continue to do so.

First, anyone seeking objective information about the war's context and background won't find it in *The New York Times*, on CNN or any other mainstream media source, all of which are simply stenographers to official power. It doesn't excuse Putin's aggressive and egregious miscalculation to cite the quarter century of US/NATO provocations and rejections of Russian security concerns that created the conditions for this conflict. A plentitude of experts in and out of government warned that NATO's relentless expansion eastward toward Russia's border was a brazen, reckless act that would virtually guarantee a military response.

After Soviet Union's dissolution in 1991, Washington promised Russia that NATO would not advance "an inch to the east" but then turned around and did exactly that by adding Eastern European countries like Poland, Latvia and Estonia. Several times, Russia made it unequivocally clear that its red line, never to be crossed, would be offering Ukraine membership in NATO. In response, the US kept taunting Russia and refusing to rule out Ukraine's NATO membership.

In 1997, 50 prominent US foreign policy experts signed an open letter to President Bill Clinton, saying "We believe that the current U.S. led effort to expand NATO...is a policy error of historical proportions that would unsettle European security." George Kennan, the dean of America's Russian expert and father of US containment strategy, wrote that "...expanding NATO would be the most fateful error of American foreign policy in the entire post-Cold War era... I think it's a tragic mistake." Former Secretary of State Henry Kissinger has long cautioned against U.S. meddling in Ukrainian affairs. And in 2000, William Burns, former US ambassador to Russia and current CIA director, wrote in his memoir, "Back Channel," that it wasn't only Putin but "Ukraine's entry into NATO is the brightest of all red lines for the Russian elites," all of whom would see it as "a direct challenge to Russian interests." Indeed, Russia may have seen this as the first step in U.S. "regime change" strategy.

In 2008, at the Bucharest summit, Germany and France adamantly opposed granting NATO membership to Ukraine because they knew, implicitly, that it was foolish and dangerous to incite Russia. Due to the fact that the US totally runs the NATO show, they buckled in the face of Washington's pressure and the final statement promised membership for Ukraine.

Second, in 2013, Ukraine became a total American project when it was widely reported that Assistant Secretary of State Victoria Nuland had bragged about the U.S. spending \$5 billion dollars to support the opposition and select the new pro-U.S. head of government. The new regime was chock full of ultra-nationalists and neo-Nazis, some of whom were fully integrated into the armed forces and others of whom assumed seats in the new Parliament.

Again, it doesn't justify Russia's invasion, but Russ Belland, the foremost expert on Ukraine's long Nazi past, reminds us that the 14th Waffen SS Division insignia can still be seen on some demonstrators and Ukrainian soldiers. In any event, a civil war followed in which 14,000 pro-Russian Ukrainians died before a temporary truce was reached. Washington poured weapons and military advisers into Ukraine, joint exercises took place between U.S. and Ukrainian forces and Washington appeared to green light Ukraine's NATO membership.

One can only imagine how the United States would respond if, say China, were to sign a "Mutual Security Pact" with Mexico and then began making preparations to install missiles with multiple nuclear warheads that could reach the East coast of the United States, including Washington, D.C. How long before the U.S. would launch a military response? Overnight? Remember the Cuba Missile Crisis in 1962? In other words, if Ukraine is free to make its own choices, does that not apply equally to Mexico or Canada?

Further, I'm guessing that very few Americans are aware that not only has the U.S. been training Ukrainians in Ukraine since 1993, but last fall, long before Russia invaded Ukraine on February 24 of this year, Ukrainian armed forces were being trained on American soil to operate missile systems at the John Stennis U.S. Space Command Center in Biloxi, Mississippi. At a minimum, shouldn't this raise questions about what the U.S. was hoping would transpire in Ukraine? Is it implausible to suggest that Washington sought to poke the Russian bear in the eye, entangle it in a "new Afghanistan" and then hope to bleed and debilitate it before the U.S. pivoted toward China? In early February, before Russia acted, Army Reserve Lt. Colonel and former Congressperson Tulsi Gabbard, said that "The Biden administration wanted Russia to invade Ukraine." Put another way, Ukraine is a U.S. proxy war with Russia in which Washington will prolong the fight to the last Ukrainian.

Finally, after a negotiated settlement in Ukraine, the U.S. will attempt to ignite Cold War, Phase 2 and Ukraine is the precursor to erecting a new iron curtain encircling Russia and China. However, the cohesion now existing between Europe and the U.S. will be short lived. Mutually beneficial trade (especially in energy) and development with Russia and China will prove irresistible. As economic analyst Michael Hudson has pointed out, there is a limit to how long European business interests will forgo the immense opportunity costs—the costs of lost opportunities—of trade and investment in Russia as the price for their continued obedience to U.S. global ambitions. In addition, Europeans will resent the fact that NATO is now an extension of the Pentagon and its taxpayers will rebel against the cost of increased defense budgets.

In that vein, all available evidence suggests that the United States will be eclipsed by China as soon as 2030 when its economy will be 60 percent larger than the United States. The period leading up to this rough demarcation line will be exceedingly dangerous because it's far from certain that the U.S. psyche can cope with this diminution in stature and peacefully accept a multipolar world. And nowhere is this more in doubt than in the Pacific in places like Taiwan and the South China Sea.

Given that China realizes that its economic might must be equaled by military might, Beijing is now militarily invincible in Asia. Further, its trade and development linkages are extending to Latin America, Africa and India. France and Ger-

many already have extensive trade ties with China. Unless the United States ceases efforts to regain global superiority and accepts being a normal country rather than the world's "exceptional country" it will be marginalized and ordinary citizens will pay an enormous price.

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**TIPS TO AVOID STRESS DUE TO
RUSSIA-UKRAINE CONFLICT**

I
Imagine that these countries are in Africa.

II
Imagine that Ukraine is Palestine.

III
Imagine that these countries are in the Middle East.

IV
Imagine that Russia is the USA.

**WITH THESE MENTAL ACTIONS YOU WILL SEE HOW
YOUR INDIFFERENCE TO THE CONFLICT GROWS**

Defining Racism: Individuals and Institutions, Systems and Structures

ROBERT JENSEN

We are at a dramatic point in the racial history of the United States, perhaps the most important moment since the civil rights and more radical black/brown/indigenous movements of the 1960s and '70s. Two dramatically different currents in American life are gaining strength: White supremacy has reasserted itself in the mainstream of public life, and at the same time a significant segment of white America is joining the struggle for racial justice.

Clichés might be the most appropriate summary: This is the best and the worst of times, a crisis fraught with danger and opportunity.

So, let's take a moment to define terms.

I know that sounds boring, but the expanded public space for conversation about racial justice in recent years has not always led to greater clarity in how we use words. For example, the terms systemic, structural, and institutional racism are often tossed into conversations without a commonly understood definition, which undermines effective communication.

There is not one correct meaning of such terms, and if there should be, I am not arrogant enough to think I can prescribe those definitions. But after more than three decades of writing, teaching, and organizing, this framework helps me understand complex problems and sort through potential solutions.

White Supremacy and Racism

Before addressing systemic, structural, and institutional racism, we should define racism itself. That starts with white supremacy, the historical system that emerged out of Europe about 500 years ago. White supremacy was not the primary motive for the European taking of much of the rest of the globe (that was mostly old-fashioned greed, self-aggrandizement, and delusional thinking), but a doctrine of white, European, and Christian supremacy evolved as a justification for conquest and hardened into dogma.

Eventually that doctrine took root in places where Europe established settler colonies, including the United States and South Africa, perhaps the two most consistently and deeply racist societies of the 20th century. European barbarism was not the first case of one group of people exterminating or exploiting others, of course, but it is the beginning of the modern conception of racism. White supremacy established the racial hierarchy that we live with today, with one racial group's domination asserted to be the "natural" order of things.

In summary: Racism is an embrace of the idea of racial hierarchy, produced by an ideology of white supremacy, which can be expressed both by individuals and through the practices of institutions.

That helps us sort out a vexing question: Who can be racist in the United States? Is racism any prejudice based on racial differences? Under that definition, a black

person who doesn't want to associate with white people, and whites who don't want to associate with blacks are all racists. Racial-justice advocates usually reject that, defining racism as "prejudice plus power," which means people of color can't be racist given their lack of collective power in a white-supremacist society.

But power is not a simple commodity that one group has exclusively and other groups lack completely. Imagine a successful black business owner passing a white homeless person panhandling on the street. If they exchanged racialized insults, who do we label a racist? What if the business owner is an immigrant from Pakistan and the panhandler is black? Is a white person's opposition to affirmative action programs evidence of racism? Does that assessment change if Chinese-Americans oppose such programs?

Rather than searching for an algorithm to answer such questions, we can say that the modern idea of racial hierarchies, with northern Europeans at the top, is the product of 500 years of white supremacy. Absent white supremacy, those questions wouldn't be asked in this fashion. Again, that doesn't mean that people always lived in peace and harmony before the European conquest of most of the rest of the world. History offers many versions of domination and subordination, justified in many different ways. But the concept of race we live with today emerges out of white supremacy.

White supremacy is not static, of course. Laws and living conditions change, but the idea of racial hierarchies remains potent, and not only in the white community. When a non-white person from one racial group uses a racist slur against someone from a different non-white group, white supremacy is strengthened. For example, the anti-black racism in various Hispanic communities doesn't prove that "everyone deep down is racist" but rather demonstrates the power of white supremacy to pull us all into accepting hierarchical social arrangements.

That's enough for us to proceed to an examination of racism at two different social levels (individual and institutional) with two different levels of awareness (overt and unconscious). In all these cases, we'll see that racism is both an idea and a set of practices.

Individuals' Overt Racism

People who say "I believe white people are smarter than [fill in the blank]" or "white people should run the world" are white supremacists. That's not controversial, but such statements are not all that common these days, even from people who otherwise sound a lot like white supremacists. The Proud Boys, which many of us consider to be an overtly racist group, is sometimes described as "a white supremacist-adjacent organization" because most of its members avoid blatant expressions of racism.

What should we call people who belong to groups that do not embrace unequivocally racist statements but instead advocate for "white pride" or "Western chauvinism"? What about politicians who deny being racist but who denounce Critical Race Theory, which they mischaracterize as antipathy toward whites? Is it accurate to describe any of these people as overt racists?

Whether or not such folks think of themselves as holding racist ideas, they are supporting racist politics. The practical outcome of their position is to shore up white supremacy, whether they agree with that assessment or not. This smacks of

telling people that they don't understand themselves, that they have motivations for their politics different than they claim. But being unaware of what our words and deeds reveal about ourselves is not unique to white supremacists; a lack of complete self-awareness is a feature of being human. We are all influenced by forces we may not fully understand, which means we don't always know ourselves very well.

Individuals' Unconscious Racism

All of us who grew up in the United States were socialized in a white-supremacist society and influenced to varying degrees by that training. Through conscious efforts, we can minimize the effects of that training, but it is the rare white person who has transcended white supremacy. We should try to self-monitor as much as possible and stay open to critiques of our behavior from others. But self-monitoring is hardly foolproof, given how easy humans can self-deceive, and avoiding critique from others is easy, especially if we live relatively segregated lives.

That means that when white people start a sentence with "I'm not a racist, but ..." the smart bet is that the next thing out of their mouth will be a racist comment. The phrase suggests a person lacks a well-developed capacity for critical self-reflection about that socialization. Most white people struggling to be anti-racist have learned not to say that. In fact, to demonstrate how seriously anti-racist they are, some white people will go the other direction, prefacing a comment with "I know I'm a racist ..." That phrase is no doubt well intentioned, signaling an awareness of that socialization, but is debilitating. If every white person, including those actively engaged in anti-racist education and organizing, is a racist then the term is simply a synonym for being white. If the leader of the local neo-Nazi group is a racist and I'm a racist, then the term loses any useful meaning.

Failing to distinguish between the two groups matters. Imagine going to white people and saying, "We want you to commit to personal and political action to challenge racism, which includes critical self-reflection about how you have internalized white supremacy, but no matter how hard you work at that, you're still a racist and always will be." That's a stunted view of human capacities for intellectual growth and moral reflection, and not exactly a great way to encourage people to embrace a movement for racial justice.

Systemic Racism

One common response to the messiness over adjudicating whether individuals' words and deeds are racist is to focus on institutions. Rather than argue about who is and isn't a racist, we can focus on what happens when people come together in groups. But we also interact daily as individuals, trying to understand one another. The macro analysis does not eliminate questions about individuals and their motivations.

But it's true that treating racism as nothing more than individual attitudes and behavior is inadequate for political change. The most common terms for this collective focus are institutional, systemic, and structural racism. I have never found widely agreed upon definitions of the terms, and sometimes they are used interchangeably. I want to suggest distinctions that might be analytically useful.

Social movements have brought significant changes: some legal, some cultural that have greatly reduced the frequency of racist expressions and behaviors in the United

States. Systemic racism suggests that the today's racist outcomes are not the product of the proverbial "few bad apples" but rather of how certain systems operate.

An example is the disproportionately high rates of disciplining black students in the U.S. public school system, the result at least in part of black children being mistakenly judged as angry more often than white children. The staffs of the nation's schools are disproportionately white, but white teachers are not more or less racist than the white population. However, assumptions and routine practices result in a pattern of teachers referring students for disciplinary action differently based on race. The problem we're focused on here is not in the criteria for discipline or how classrooms are organized, which one may want to change for other reasons, but in how those criteria are applied.

In such a system, it would be possible to change racist outcomes by retraining existing personnel or replacing them with anti-racist staff, and hiring more teachers of color. Racism is systemic, in the sense of being present throughout the system, but not necessarily a permanent feature of the system. We can imagine the same system producing less racist outcomes with modifications. In the face of systemic racism, individuals' actions can make a significant difference when people work together to change the routines and challenge racist attitudes and behavior.

Structural Racism

I suggest we use the term structural racism for systems in which white supremacy is more "baked in," making a more fundamental change in structure necessary. Again, schools provide a good example.

In the United States, public education is funded partly through local property taxes. That means wealthier school districts can raise more money for education than poorer districts. That may be in general unfair, but it becomes structurally racist when we take into consideration two other facts: There is a racialized wealth gap, especially between white and black/brown communities, and the United States is still overwhelmingly segregated in terms of housing. The result is that black and brown children will, on average compared with white children, attend schools with fewer financial resources. Those students will go to schools with less experienced teachers, fewer technological resources, older textbooks, fewer enrichment programs, and school facilities not as well maintained. Those non-white children will not get, on average, an education equal to white children.

Public education is unequal in resource allocation not because of individual attitudes and behaviors but because of larger choices made long ago about structuring school funding, making it a kind of structural racism. Dedicated teachers working in such a system can lessen the effects of the funding disparities, but on average black and brown children will not get the same education as white children.

That leaves the term institutional racism, which could be a synonym for either systemic or structural racism, and people seem to use it both ways. In previous writing I used it to mean structural racism, but today I lean toward using it as an umbrella term for both the systemic and structural. Again, there's not a single right way to define these terms. The goal is coming to shared understanding to improve communication, sharpen analysis, and guide policy.

Implications

Clear definitions help us evaluate policy options. In our school examples, when the problem is systemic racism, there are certain remedies to pursue, mostly focused on improving or changing personnel, or instituting a review system so that racist patterns in decisions can be identified and reversed. That's not easy but doesn't necessarily require that the system be redesigned.

When the problem is structural racism, more fundamental changes are needed, which often is much harder. In the school funding example, one response would be to abandon local revenue sources and fund all public schools in the country at exactly the same level, which would require federal government oversight and revenues, which means additional taxes. That not only would be opposed by white supremacists but also goes against the idea that schools function best with active involvement of not only parents but local communities, which might be threatened by federal intervention.

If uniform public-school funding could be achieved, there's still another hurdle: wealthier parents, who are disproportionately white, can enroll their children in private schools. To eliminate that disparity, should we cap private-school spending to the same per-student level as public schools, or even outlaw private schools altogether? An even more ambitious approach would be to reduce the racialized wealth gap by redistributionist policies. Since capitalism is a wealth-concentrating system, do we have to tame it with aggressive public policy or come up with a new way of organizing economic activity? Until then, should we institute policies that reduce housing segregation by increasing subsidized housing in every wealthy neighborhood?

Whatever one thinks of these potential solutions, they require significant overhauls of not just the public schools but the whole society.

Case Study: Policing and Prisons

A common focus of the discussion of racism over the past few years has been policing and prisons the disproportionate use of force, including deadly force, against black and brown people, and the disproportionate rate of incarceration for black and brown people. Are these examples of systemic or structural racism, or both?

Many police forces include officers with racist attitudes, but the bigger problem is everyday routines. The problem is not just a few bad cops but a system that leads to police officers targeting black and brown people. When people with white-supremacist assumptions set policy, dictate procedures, and determine best practices, the result is systemic racism.

What if we were to go deeper and ask about the purpose of the criminal justice system in this society? Once we move beyond rhetoric about keeping people safe, which certainly is one thing policing can accomplish, it's clear that the legal system is also a system of social control in a capitalist economy marked by dramatic wealth inequality.

For example, drug use occurs in every society at every level, but criminalizing drugs leads to law enforcement focusing on poorer people while largely ignoring the affluent, who take fewer risks when buying drugs and have greater resources to fight charges. Some critics have suggested the drug laws are designed to control the "dangerous classes" that threaten concentrated wealth. Meanwhile, warehousing poor

people in prisons increases racialized wealth inequality and creates an incarceration economy, in which both owners of private prison corporations and working people who take jobs as guards in public prisons have a stake in protecting this approach to law enforcement.

The current crises in law enforcement and criminal justice are examples of both systemic and structural racism. Changes in hiring and training practices could potentially address the systemic racism. The structural racism poses a more difficult challenge. How much progress can be made in a capitalist system with its inevitable wealth inequality? Capitalism celebrates that inequality as the necessary motivation for innovation and production. Does the end of white supremacy require the end of capitalism?

And if we go deeper, another set of questions emerges: Are any of these changes likely without a simultaneous challenge to the domination/subordination dynamic at the heart of patriarchy? Male dominance is the oldest social system not just centuries but millennia old that justifies one group's power over another by claiming such domination is natural. Does the end of white supremacy require the end of patriarchy as well?

White Supremacy, not Whiteness

A digression of sorts, but important: I have repeatedly referred to white supremacy but avoided "whiteness." That term is in vogue these days but too often gets used in analytically sloppy fashion. Here's an example.

In an email exchange I was part of, a white educator committed to anti-racism criticized an essay about the complex ways our brains make sense of the world. My colleague said that such analyses "that ignore or are unaware of how other cultures have looked at this, and only focus on Western science, are practicing whiteness blatantly." There certainly are varied cultural traditions that provide insights into these questions, but I challenged the conflation of science and whiteness. Modern science emerged out of Europe, of course, but what does it mean to say that practicing modern science is "practicing whiteness"? Other traditions, with systems of knowledge that predate modern science, have much to offer, but modern science has expanded human knowledge in ways that are unprecedented. Is that statement, which strikes me as an uncontroversial observation about human history, somehow an expression of whiteness? If there are non-white people who agree with that statement, are they also practicing whiteness?

The essay in question discussed the complexity of the interplay of reason and emotion. I also pointed out that feminist philosophy that I started reading in the late 1980s while in graduate school also challenged a sharp reason/emotion dichotomy. But I wouldn't say it's patriarchal for neuroscientists to pursue these questions using the methods of their discipline. Sexism has shaped modern science in certain ways, as it has shaped every institution in patriarchal societies, but I wouldn't say that the writer of that essay was "practicing maleness" because he focused on neuroscience and ignored feminist philosophy in a short newspaper essay.

This expansive use of whiteness as a pejorative can take strange turns. In a news story about the controversy over a professor's argument against affirmative action, one

of the sources quoted seemed to challenge the value of academic debate: “This idea of intellectual debate and rigor as the pinnacle of intellectualism comes from a world in which white men dominated.” Although the professor quoted has argued that her point has been distorted, what kind of intellectual life is possible if we reject the idea that people with conflicting theories and ideas should seek to resolve the conflict, which implies debate? Should we not strive for rigor, the careful assessment of evidence? Life is about more than theories and abstract ideas, and we don’t demand scholarly rigor in every aspect of everyday life. But in intellectual life, as we try to deepen our understanding of how the world works, debate is inevitable and rigor is essential.

The value of “objectivity” also shows up on lists of features of “white supremacy culture.” There are lots of reasons to critique how objectivity plays out in different professions, and I’ve written about the limits of so-called objectivity routines in journalism, suggesting that these routines can actually distort accounts of reality. But if objectivity means the attempt to get the most complete account of reality possible, by searching for all relevant evidence, then how is objectivity a bad thing? Why is objectivity an outgrowth of whiteness? Would that mean that accepting incomplete accounts of reality is an outgrowth of non-white cultures? Some people argue that narratives are just as important as more formal forms of inquiry, and I agree. We learn a lot from people’s stories. But honoring the value of narratives doesn’t mean taking everyone’s stories at face value without challenge. We are always making judgments about the information we take in, and the concept of objectivity, properly understood, is a good guide for those judgments. Objectivity in that sense doesn’t introduce bias but is a corrective to the potential bias that so easily sneaks into our thinking.

These kinds of assertions about whiteness are simplistic and counterproductive. Because they are so easy to caricature, reactionary politicians use them to undermine the struggle to press white America to come to terms with systemic and structural racism. Nothing is gained by reducing complex history to reflexive assertions of good (all things non-white) and bad (anything related to white). That’s actually a kind of binary thinking that progressive activists tell us, appropriately, to avoid.

Avoiding False Alternatives

Anti-racist activists routinely emphasize the need to focus not just on changing racist individuals but on the systems and structural features that embed racism in the culture. Fair enough, but the two are inextricably linked. The collective actions to overhaul or replace a system require the political power to make large-scale change. For movements to assert that kind of political power, they must be large enough to make demands that politicians take seriously, which means persuading more individuals to embrace anti-racist politics.

What does all this demand of us? Those of us who believe ourselves to be anti-racist need the conviction to remain committed to large-scale change while being self-critical. People who mistakenly believe that racial justice has been achieved need to recognize the need for deeper change. And people who hang onto overtly racist ideas and practices have to be challenged. All these efforts are important.

A social movement doesn’t need the support of 100% of the public to make effective change, but racial-justice movements need more people on board. Changing

the hearts and minds of individuals is part of the process of systemic and structural change, and it requires thoughtful conversations that can resonate with ordinary people, not jargon and dogma.

Intersectionality

Groupthink is a real threat in any human project, and progressive social movements are not immune from developing an insider language that makes outsiders feel excluded or condescended to. An example is the trajectory of “intersectionality.”

Intersectionality began as a useful term to explain the limits of anti-discrimination law, which made it hard to bring claims that deal with both sexism and racism. From there, the term more generally came to be used to remind us how multiple systems of dominance play out in everyday life, especially the categories of race, sex, and class. The term challenges us to go deeper. But once it becomes jargon, it also can inhibit critical self-reflection.

The case study I’m most familiar with concerns the pornography industry. For more than three decades, I’ve been part of a radical feminist anti-pornography movement that argues pornography is not just harmless images of sex but one way the culture eroticizes domination and subordination, especially male domination and female subordination. Men routinely facilitate masturbation with images that include the sexualized degradation of women. But it doesn’t stop there. Pornography is also the most overtly racist media genre in the world, using every racist stereotype imaginable to increase men’s sexual pleasure by adding that form of domination/subordination to the pornography playbook. This production of endless images of objectified female bodies presented primarily for men’s sexual pleasure is fueled by capitalism, an amoral economic system that values only profit. Pornography produces a product for a market, without concern for the effects on the women used in the production, the women against whom pornography is used in sexual coercion, or the larger shaping of society’s attitudes about power and sex.

One might think that anyone with an intersectional analysis would oppose the pornography industry and challenge images that sexualize cruelty toward women and eroticize racism. But many people who consider themselves intersectional feminists reject this analysis and either refuse to critique the industry or even embrace it as a site of sexual liberation. I’ve talked to people who wave away the feminist critique as old-fashioned and out of date simply by saying, “I’m an intersectional feminist.” These folks typically defend their position with the claim that they are standing up for the women used in pornography, using the neoliberal term “sex workers,” falsely implying that critics of pornography blame the women used in the industry and deceptively suggesting that sexual exploitation is like any other work.

Why do people who identify as intersectional feminists ignore an intersectional analysis of pornography and other sexual-exploitation industries such as prostitution and stripping? Why do people who would be quick to condemn sexist and racist representations in mainstream media turn away from the much more intense sexism and racism in pornography? I’ve written about that elsewhere, but here will only point out that an important concept such as intersectionality that is so useful in addressing hard questions can also become jargon that people use to deflect attention from hard questions.

Conclusion

We need to seek clarity about complexity, carefully. The world is infinitely complex, far beyond human abilities to fully understand. So, we simplify. We create categories to organize reality, in order to help us cope with that complexity. That's part of being human, but it requires eternal vigilance to make sure we don't start to believe that our simplifications of reality are reality itself. History is messier than any human theory can account for.

Here's my summary of that messiness: If we want to create a more just and sustainable world, we best keep two things in mind about racism. First, the United States is less racist than ever before. Second, the United States will never overcome white supremacy.

That we are a less racist country can be demonstrated by a simple question: Would anyone like to return to the racial status quo in 1958, the year I was born? At the time, the United States was an apartheid society, based on the denial of citizenship to many non-white people. Racist cultural assumptions were the norm throughout the country, and violent assertions of white supremacy were common in certain regions. Time travel back to 1958? No thanks. How about 1968, when social movements were struggling to end apartheid? Even in 2008, when the United States elected a black president, were we a less racist country? Has there been a moment in U.S. history that was less racist than today? If so, when was that? It's important to acknowledge this progress if we want to be effective politically, and to honor the many people who struggled, suffered, took risks, and sometimes died to end American apartheid.

The argument that the United States will never overcome white supremacy is less obvious. I don't mean that a progressive politics is doomed to fail, but rather that if white society could let go of white supremacy in all its manifestations, we would be a radically different country.

The land base and the phenomenal wealth of the United States are based on (1) the almost complete extermination of the indigenous population to create the country; (2) African slavery to create the wealth that propelled the country into the industrial era; and (3) the 20th century exploitation of the Global South, often imposed through brutal military force. These three racialized holocausts have made the country the richest in the history of the world. All those holocaust-level crimes involving millions of deaths, incalculable suffering, and the destruction of entire societies were motivated by greed but justified by, and made politically possible because of, white supremacy. We will not transcend white supremacy until we can collectively tell the truth about those crimes. The society that could ever get to that place would be, I suspect, so different from the country we live in that it wouldn't be the same country.

We've taken significant steps toward racial justice, and a long journey lies ahead. Both things are true and both things are relevant in trying to understand a complex world.

Social movements challenging deeply entrenched injustice need to be honest about the difficulty of that struggle. At the same time, those movements have to help people imagine that the more radical change in unjust systems is possible. Organizers develop strategies and slogans that emphasize "sí, se puede" (the slogan of the United Farmworkers, typically translated as "yes, we can") even when success is unlikely, at

least in the short term. Strategies and slogans designed to motivate people, especially to stay committed over the long haul, are important. But those strategies should be based on careful assessment of the level of change needed to reach a goal and the impediments to that change. That analysis is aided by clarity in definitions, which is necessary to counter the tendency toward jargon and dogma that creates a sense of in-group belonging.

I realize this presentation reflects my personality. I like precision in language. I'm not energized by chants. When someone offers a slogan, my instinct is not to repeat it but to ask what it means. Both aspects of the human animal—the desire to come together with others in a cause that lifts our spirits, and the quest to deepen our understanding of a complex world—are integral ingredients to the struggle for a better world.

There's no doubt that passion is the engine drives history, but as my late friend and radical activist Abe Osheroff used to say, when we board that train of human history we should remember to bring along our carry-on luggage of critical reasoning.

A version of this essay was presented to the National Conference on Racial and Social Justice on November 17, 2021.

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In Praise of “Whataboutism”

MARGARET KIMBERLEY

The word “whataboutism” is used to silence and insult opponents of U.S. imperialism. It should be embraced as a means of revealing what is too often kept hidden.

Anyone who speaks out against imperialism, capitalism, or racism with concrete examples of the terrible harm they do, can expect to be charged with the dreaded term “whataboutism.” Like clockwork, the act of revealing American crimes will result in an accusation that is used to silence dissent.

When war propaganda prevails regarding Ukraine or any other place where the hegemon is doing its dirty work, it is reasonable to ask probing questions. Why are the deaths of 14,000 people killed by Ukraine’s civil war swept under the rug? Why is it forbidden to ask about the U.S. destruction of Libya? But once having asked a good question, one will be told that raising the topic is proof of the whataboutism sin.

The word whataboutism is in the [dictionary](#) and is defined as, “the act or practice of responding to an accusation of wrongdoing by claiming that an offense committed by another is similar or worse.” That meaning is accurate and also completely defensible.

The charge is meant to censor the speaker, excuse U.S. actions, and defend its human rights violations. The denials and apologies are exactly why whataboutism should be defended. It is terrible when lies and crimes are not countered with verifiable information exposing them.

The term has gained popularity in part because there is so much hypocrisy to point out and there are so many adherents to American exceptionalism who defend what they should condemn. When the [International Criminal Court \(ICC\)](#) announced that it would begin investigating “the Situation in Ukraine” corporate media and their political partners gloated and pointed fingers at Russia. They didn’t point out that the U.S., like Russia, is not a signatory of the Treaty of Rome which brought the ICC into existence. Not only is the U.S. not a member state, but in 2002 Congress passed the [American Service Members Protection Act](#), popularly known as the Hague Invasion Act. It gives the U.S. the right to extract any American held at the court in the Hague. The removal part isn’t even necessary because the act prohibits the extradition of Americans to the ICC.

The chest thumping about the investigation into Ukraine should surely be followed by a discussion of U.S. hostility to the ICC. It is a clear example of when and how whataboutism should be practiced. Not mentioning the U.S. relationship or rather lack of relationship with the ICC would be an indication of agreement with exceptionalist doctrine.

If Vladimir Putin is described as a war criminal, thug, dictator, and a modern day Hitler, it is appropriate and indeed necessary to ask about American presidents. For brevity’s sake consider only those American presidents who served since 2001. U.S. invasions and interventions in western Asia, North Africa, central Asia and the Horn of Africa have displaced more than [37 million people](#) since the “war on terror” began. Why shouldn’t George W. Bush, Barack Obama, Donald Trump, and

Joe Biden be called war criminals too? Silence in the face of their criminality gives license and approval to U.S. aggressions.

American exceptionalism is an illness which infects most of the population of this country. Unfortunately most people need little prompting to defend their nation’s misdeeds. George W. Bush is now thought of as a kindly old man who paints pictures of puppies. There is little inclination to acknowledge the one million dead from the Iraq invasion. Doing so would create great discomfort.

Every news story about migrants attempting a perilous crossing from North Africa to Europe should mention the destruction of Libya which took place under the direction of Barack Obama. But Obama is the first Black president, and he is still considered a model of rectitude, a man who brought hope and change. Pointing out his responsibility for an ongoing humanitarian crisis is too much for people propagandized into believing in his goodness and the nation’s.

Even Donald Trump, who is ordinarily disparaged and reviled, is not called out for continuing his predecessors’ wars or for killing at least [40,000](#) Venezuelans through his sanctions regime. Trump derangement syndrome doesn’t extend to his crimes against people of the global south. The power of the white supremacist exceptionalist myth has a very strong hold.

That myth can’t be rooted out and destroyed unless inconvenient facts are brought to light. If the clueless and compromised want to shout, “Whataboutism!” at the top of their lungs by all means they should do so. Although the targets of their scorn should not feel the need to justify themselves. In fact they should proudly own the word, and double down on providing whatever information is causing cognitive dissonance.

The world needs to know about America’s crimes and those of its allies too. When the same European nations that turn away African and Middle Eastern refugees announce that they will accept any and all Ukrainians surely whataboutism is in order. When Biden presumes to lecture Russia, his decision to steal \$7 billion in Afghanistan’s assets should be brought to light. Afghans are in such a desperate state that many of them resort to [selling their kidneys](#) in order to feed themselves.

The crisis in Ukraine is just the latest example of an opportunity to point out the wrongs committed by the U.S. and its partners. No one should shrink from doing so, not even when whataboutism is used as a pejorative instead of as the badge of honor that it is.

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Learning the Wrong Lessons from Ukraine

DAVID SWANSON

Ukraine gave up its nuclear weapons and was attacked. Therefore, every country should have nuclear weapons.

NATO didn't add Ukraine, which was attacked. Therefore, every country or at least lots of them should be added to NATO.

Russia has a bad government. Therefore, it should be overthrown.

These lessons are popular, logical—even unquestionable truth in many minds—and catastrophically and demonstrably wrong.

The world has had incredibly good luck and a ridiculously high number of near misses with nuclear weapons. The mere passage of time makes nuclear apocalypse extremely likely. The scientists who maintain the Doomsday Clock say the risk is now greater than ever before. Exacerbating it with even more proliferation only adds to the risk. For those who rank the survival of life on Earth above any aspect of what that life looks like (for you can waive no flag and hate no enemy if you don't exist) eliminating nuclear weapons has to be a top priority, just like eliminating climate-destroying emissions.

But what if every country that gives up nukes gets attacked? That would be a steep price indeed, but it isn't the case. Kazakhstan also gave up its nukes. So did Belarus. South Africa gave up its nukes. Brazil and Argentina chose not to have nukes. South Korea, Taiwan, Sweden, and Japan have chosen not to have nukes. Now, it is true that Libya gave up its nuclear weapons program and was attacked. And it is true that numerous countries lacking nuclear weapons have been attacked: Iraq, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Syria, Yemen, Somalia, etc. But nuclear weapons don't completely stop India and Pakistan attacking each other, don't stop terrorism in the U.S. or Europe, don't prevent a major proxy war with the U.S. and Europe arming Ukraine against Russia, don't stop a major push for war with China, don't prevent Afghans and Iraqis and Syrians fighting against the U.S. military, and have as much to do with starting the war in Ukraine as their absence does with failing to prevent it.

The Cuban missile crisis involved the U.S. objecting to Soviet missiles in Cuba, and the USSR objecting to U.S. missiles in Turkey and Italy. In more recent years, the U.S. has abandoned numerous disarmament agreements, maintained nuclear missiles in Turkey (and Italy, Germany, Netherlands, and Belgium), and placed new missile bases in Poland and Romania. Among Russia's excuses for invading Ukraine was the positioning of weaponry nearer its border than ever before. Excuses, needless to say, are not justifications, and the lesson learned in Russia that the U.S. and NATO will listen to nothing other than war is as false a lesson as those being learned in the U.S. and Europe. Russia could have supported the rule of law and won over much of the world to its side. It chose not to.

In fact, the United States and Russia are not parties to the International Criminal Court. The United States punishes other governments for supporting the ICC.

The United States and Russia defy the rulings of the International Court of Justice. The U.S.-backed coup in Ukraine in 2014, the U.S. and Russian efforts to win over Ukraine for years, the mutual arming of conflict in Donbas, and the Russian invasion of 2021 highlight a problem in world leadership.

Of 18 major human rights treaties, Russia is party to only 11, and the United States to only 5, as few as any nation on Earth. Both nations violate treaties at will, including the United Nations Charter, Kellogg-Briand Pact, and other laws against war. Both nations refuse to support and openly defy major disarmament and anti-weapons treaties upheld by most of the world. Neither supports the Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons. Neither complies with the disarmament requirement of the Nuclear Nonproliferation Treaty, and the United States actually keeps nuclear weapons in five other nations and considers putting them into more, while Russia has talked of putting nukes in Belarus.

Russia and the United States stand as rogue regimes outside the Landmines Treaty, the Convention on Cluster Munitions, the Arms Trade Treaty, and many others. The United States and Russia are the top two dealers of weaponry to the rest of the world, together accounting for a large majority of weapons sold and shipped. Meanwhile most places experiencing wars manufacture no weapons at all. Weapons are imported to most of the world from a very few places. The United States and Russia are the top two users of the veto power at the UN Security Council, each frequently shutting down democracy with a single vote.

Russia could have prevented the invasion of Ukraine by not invading Ukraine. Europe could have prevented the invasion of Ukraine by telling the U.S. and Russia to mind their own business. The United States could almost certainly have prevented the invasion of Ukraine by any of the following steps, which U.S. experts warned were needed to avoid war with Russia:

- Abolishing NATO when the Warsaw Pact was abolished.
- Refraining from expanding NATO.
- Refraining from supporting color revolutions and coups.
- Supporting nonviolent action, training in unarmed resistance, and neutrality.
- Transitioning from fossil fuels.
- Refraining from arming Ukraine, weaponizing Eastern Europe, and conducting war rehearsals in Eastern Europe.
- Accepting Russia's perfectly reasonable demands in December 2021.

In 2014, Russia proposed that Ukraine align with neither the West nor the East but work with both. The U.S. rejected that idea and supported a military coup that installed a pro-West government.

According to Ted Snider: "In 2019, Volodymyr Zelensky was elected on a platform that featured making peace with Russia and signing the Minsk Agreement. The Minsk Agreement offered autonomy to the Donetsk and Lugansk regions of the Donbas that had voted for independence from Ukraine after the coup. It offered the most promising diplomatic solution. Facing domestic pressure, though, Zelensky would need U.S. support. He did not get it and, in the words of Richard Sakwa, Professor

of Russian and European Politics at the University of Kent, he was ‘thwarted by the nationalists.’ Zelensky stepped off the road of diplomacy and refused to talk to the leaders of the Donbas and implement the Minsk Agreements.

“Having failed to support Zelensky on a diplomatic solution with Russia, Washington then failed to pressure him to return to the implementation of the Minsk Agreement. Sakwa told this writer that, ‘as for Minsk, neither the U.S. nor the EU put serious pressure on Kyiv to fulfill its part of the agreement.’ Though the U.S. officially endorsed Minsk, Anatol Lieven, senior research fellow on Russia and Europe at the Quincy Institute for Responsible Statecraft, told this writer, ‘they did nothing to push Ukraine into actually implementing it.’ The Ukrainians gave Zelensky a mandate for a diplomatic solution. Washington did not support or encourage it.”

While even U.S. President Barack Obama opposed arming Ukraine, Trump and Biden favored it, and now Washington has dramatically increased it. After eight years of assisting the Ukrainian side in a conflict in Donbas, and with branches of the U.S. military like the RAND Corporation producing reports on how to get Russia into a damaging war on Ukraine, the U.S. has refused any steps that might bring about a ceasefire and peace negotiations. As with its eternal belief that the President of Syria has been about to be overthrown any moment, and its repeated rejections of peace settlements for that country, the U.S. government, according to President Biden, favors the overthrow of the Russian government, no matter how many Ukrainians die. And the Ukrainian government seems to largely agree. Ukrainian President Zelensky reportedly rejected a peace offer days before the invasion on terms that will almost certainly ultimately be accepted by those if any left alive.

It’s a very well-kept secret, but peace is not fragile or difficult. Getting a war started is extremely difficult. It requires a concerted effort to avoid peace. The examples that prove this claim include every past war on Earth. The example most often raised in comparison with Ukraine is the Gulf War of 1990-1991. But that example depends on erasing from our collective/corporate memory the fact that the Iraqi government was willing to negotiate withdrawal from Kuwait without war and ultimately offered to simply withdraw from Kuwait within three weeks without conditions. The King of Jordan, the Pope, the President of France, the President of the Soviet Union, and many others urged such a peaceful settlement, but the White House insisted upon its “last resort” of war. Russia has been listing what it would take to end the war on Ukraine since before the war began — demands that ought to be countered with other demands, not weaponry.

For those who have time to learn the history and understand that peace is perfectly possible, it may become easier to recognize the flaw in the self-fulfilling idea that NATO must be expanded even if it threatens Russia, and even if Russia attacks to prevent it. The belief that the Russian government would attack anywhere it could get away with no matter what, even if admitted into NATO and the EU, or even if NATO were abolished, is unprovable. But we don’t need to consider it wrong. It could very well be right. Certainly the same seems as likely to be true of the U.S. and some other governments. But refraining from expanding NATO would not have prevented Russia attacking Ukraine because the Russian government is a noble philanthropic operation. It would have prevented Russia attacking Ukraine because the Russian

government would have had no good excuse to sell to the Russian elites, the Russian public, or the world.

During the 20th Century Cold War there were examples — some of them discussed in Andrew Cockburn’s latest book — of the U.S. and Soviet militaries causing high-profile incidents just when the other side was pursuing additional weapons funding from its government. Russia’s invasion of Ukraine has done more for NATO than NATO could ever have done on its own. NATO’s support for militarism in Ukraine and Eastern Europe in recent years has done more for Russian militarism than anyone in Russia could have managed. The idea that what’s needed now is more of what created the current conflict amounts to confirming preconceptions in dire need of being questioned.

The idea that Russia has a bad government and should therefore be overthrown is a horrible thing for U.S. officials to be saying. Everywhere on Earth has a bad government. They should all be overthrown. The U.S. government arms and funds almost all of the worst governments in the world, and the easy first step of ceasing to do that is highly to be encouraged. But overthrowing governments without a massive popular and independent local movement unencumbered by outside and elite forces is an endlessly proven recipe for disaster. I’m still not clear what it is that rehabilitated George W. Bush, but am old enough to remember when even occasional news viewers had learned that overthrowing governments was a disaster even on its own terms, and that the top idea for spreading democracy would be to lead by example through trying it in one’s own country.

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Western rush to ban everything Russian, from cats to Dostoevsky, smacks of totalitarianism

JOSEPH MASSAD

Western Russophobic hysteria is now in full force. German political culture, heir of the most totalitarian system the world has ever known, has led to the recent firing of a Russian orchestra conductor who refused to condemn Moscow's military actions in Ukraine, and Russian opera singer Anna Netrebko.

As a German Jewish activist friend recently told me, this incident is not totally unrelated to the firing of German Jewish musicians in 1933 as well as German Christian musicians for refusing to support National Socialism, and that was before the 1935 Nuremberg Laws.

And a few weeks ago, Germany's state-owned Deutsche Welle was busy purging Arab staff who expressed views critical of Israel—views that are identified in rabidly pro-Israel Germany as “anti-Semitic”.

In Italy, whose political culture is also an heir of fascism, a university course on Dostoevsky was suspended in the name of the new Russophobia - though as a result of pressure, it was later reinstated. In the US, video game giant EA Sports removed Russian teams from its FIFA video game series.

The Russophobic campaign straddles the entire western political spectrum, and it is fully endorsed by western liberals and cultural elites. The political credulity of the majority of the populations of the US and Western Europe has always been shocking to me. Ever since I arrived in the US to attend university in 1982, I could not believe how gullible my American peers of all races were in their unshakable belief that whatever their government or corporate media said, especially about other countries, was the absolute truth.

Having grown up in Jordan under an autocratic regime, I learned, like many Jordanians, to believe very little that the government or media said. I remain partial to the idea that autocratic regimes foster democratic skepticism in their populations, while western liberal “democratic” regimes foster utter conformity and subservience to the “Ministry of Truth”, as George Orwell dubbed it.

Add to that the mob mentality and mainstream rejection of contrary opinions to prevalent beliefs in most western countries, and the situation is not that different from the fascistic culture of many European countries in the interwar period.

Incessant Racist Attacks

None of this is surprising. In the US, Americans shot Dachshunds in large numbers, stoned them, and stomped on them in the streets during World War I on account of their German pedigree. An American campaign was launched against beer as a German beverage, purporting that it was “unpatriotic” to drink it. Americans even renamed sauerkraut “liberty cabbage”.

This is in addition to the fact that German Americans and German residents of the US were placed in concentration camps (called “internment camps” in official lingo) during WWI and WWII.

In the 1970s and 1980s, US jingoism was at an all-time high, with incessant racist attacks on Japan for allegedly undermining the US economy. Campaigns to boycott Japanese cars and electronics were widespread, with some accusing the Japanese of committing an “economic Pearl Harbor” and warning that the “Yellow Peril” was back (here, it should be remembered that Japanese Americans and Japanese residents of the US were shipped to concentration camps during World War II and had their property confiscated by the US government).

In 1982, two white men who worked in the auto sector beat a Chinese American man to death, apparently mistaking him for being Japanese. The two killers were fined \$3,000 and did not serve jail time. US congressional representatives even used sledgehammers to destroy Toshiba products in front of the Capitol—and that was in the era of President Ronald Reagan, long before Donald Trump and Joe Biden.

After the Iranian Revolution, racist attacks and harassment of Iranians, or anyone mistaken for them (as I was by white fraternity boys a week after my arrival in the US), was the order of the day in the US. An anti-Iranian poster has been hanging at a Houston, Texas BBQ restaurant since 1979, showing a reenactment of lynching, something that endeared it to fans as late as 2011.

The Islamophobic pitch was raised to unprecedented proportions across the US and Europe after 9/11, with one of the earliest racist attacks killing, alongside a Muslim victim, an Egyptian Christian and a Sikh man who were apparently mistaken for Muslims.

Theatrical Adolescence

When France refused to support the US imperial invasion of Iraq in 2003, American restaurateurs began to throw away French wine and pour the content of bottles in the streets. Congress was also pioneering in that regard when the Congressional cafeteria renamed “French fries” as “freedom fries”.

In the current atmosphere, the same theatrical adolescence of US political culture manifested in ditching Russian vodka and even boycotting American-owned Russian restaurants. Spotify closed down its Moscow offices and IKEA closed its Russian stores. The Glasgow film festival dropped two Russian films.

Not to be outdone, New York's Metropolitan Opera declared that it was ending its partnership with Moscow's Bolshoi Theatre and cut ties with opera singer Anna Netrebko, while the Venice Biennale removed the Russian Pavilion, amongst a flurry of boycotts of Russian cultural products.

And, if German dogs had to be killed in the US during WWI, the France-based International Cat Federation has just banned Russian cats from competitions. Lithuania went as far as stopping its shipment of Covid vaccines to Bangladesh as punishment for the latter's decision to abstain on the UN vote to condemn Russian intervention. If the West were not so hypocritical about which countries could be quickly boycotted and which could not, boycotting Russia at the official level could be an important political act, including canceling state visits, joint military exercises,

declining official invitations to government-sponsored events, cancelling invitations for Russian state officials to speak at private or public institutions, etc.; however, boycotting Dostoevsky, Vodka, and Russian musicians is not.

Imposing litmus tests on Russian musicians to keep their jobs in German orchestras smacks of nothing less than totalitarianism. Just think of how controversial the boycott—not of Israel—but of its illegal settler-colonies in the occupied territories has been over the last two decades, and you get the picture.

Vladimir Lenin castigated some Russian communists in the early 1920s for their lackluster support for the rights of many non-Russian peoples inhabiting Russia by declaring: “Scratch some [Russian] communists and you will find Great-Russian chauvinists.”

As the ongoing Russophobic campaigns have unified western conservatives and liberals in the US and Europe, I feel confident in saying that most likely if you scratch many a white liberal, you will find a white supremacist Cold Warrior.

Ironic Phenomenon

The recent contemptible and despicable Russophobic acts reveal that the juvenile nature of US or West European political culture under fascism or liberalism is not so different when it comes to heaping racist scorn and fabricated fantasies on chosen enemies.

This also extends to western academia. Sovietology, a right-wing academic discipline that emerged in the 1950s, propagated sophomoric theories about Soviet “anti-democratic” culture as due to the fact that Russian mothers swaddled their babies more tightly than in other nations, an act that allegedly ingrained in them the love of being politically constricted. Arabs and Muslims, western academia and media told us for decades on end and continue to tell us, love dictators and violence, as it is part of their religion and culture.

In the year 2000, I co-organized with Edward Said a large literary conference to which we invited 40 world-famous literary figures, including 20 novelists and poets from the Arab world. The conference was funded by a private American cultural foundation and was to take place at Columbia University, where both Said and I taught.

Weeks before the conference was to be held, the 9/11 attacks took place. The anti-Arab and anti-Muslim hysteria that engulfed the US in the aftermath of the attacks greatly worried the sponsor and the university with regards to security issues and fear that the conference would be bombed by anti-Arab US zealots. As the security requirements of the university increased, the cultural foundation’s anxiety about security threats surged. The conference, which was two years in the making, was canceled.

The ironic phenomenon of western mainstream political and popular culture being most conformist and lacking dissidence, except on questions that western elites themselves are in disagreement, persists in the face of western propagandistic notions that the liberal West is the place where a “hundred flowers bloom”, unless of course they bloom in a direction that opposes the political mantra churned out by governments and the corporate media, in which case western mobs are unleashed.

A few decades ago, Noam Chomsky analyzed how the western manufacturing of consent to produce an obsequious populace had been achieved. If the current western hysteria is any indication, very little has changed in the intervening years.

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“...we must get rid of Russian roulette. That doesn’t mean that Americans have to stop playing dangerous games of chance, whether it’s pointing revolvers at our heads or eating 14 meals per week at Denny’s. Instead, let’s start calling it Freedom Roulette, a term that can cover both the gun game and the Denny’s thing.”

—The Intercept being ironic

Navigating our Humanity: Four Lessons from Ukraine

ILAN PAPPÉ

USA Today reported that a photo that went viral about a high-rise in the Ukraine being hit by Russian bombing turned out to be a high-rise from the Gaza Strip, [demolished](#) by the Israeli Air Force in May 2021. A few days before that, the Ukrainian Foreign Minister complained to the Israeli ambassador in Kiev that “you’re treating us like Gaza”; he was furious that Israel did not condemn the Russian invasion and was only interested in evicting Israeli citizens from the state (*Haaretz*, February 17, 2022). It was a mixture of reference to the Ukrainian evacuation of Ukrainian spouses of Palestinian men from the Gaza Strip in May 2021, as well as a reminder to Israel of the Ukrainian president’s full support for Israel’s assault on the Gaza Strip in that month (I will return to that support towards the end of this piece).

Israel’s assaults on Gaza should, indeed, be mentioned and considered when evaluating the present crisis in the Ukraine. It is not a coincidence that photos are being confused—there are not many high-rises that were toppled in the Ukraine, but there is an abundance of ruined high-rises in the Gaza Strip. However, it is not only the hypocrisy about Palestine that emerges when we consider the Ukraine crisis in a wider context; it is the overall Western double standards that should be scrutinized, without, for one moment, being indifferent to news and images coming to us from the war zone in the Ukraine: traumatized children, streams of refugees, sights of buildings ruined by bombing and the looming danger that this is only the beginning of a human catastrophe at the heart of Europe.

At the same time, those of us experiencing, reporting and digesting the human catastrophes in Palestine cannot escape the hypocrisy of the West and we can point to it without belittling, for a moment, our human solidarity and empathy with victims of any war. We need to do this, since the moral dishonesty underwriting the deceitful agenda set by the Western political elites and media will once more allow them to hide their own racism and impunity as it will continue to provide immunity for Israel and its oppression of the Palestinians. I detected four false assumptions which are at the heart of the Western elite’s engagement with the Ukraine crisis, so far, and have framed them as four lessons.

Lesson One: White Refugees are Welcome; Others Less So

The unprecedented collective EU decision to open up its borders to the Ukrainian refugees, followed by a more guarded policy by Britain, cannot go unnoticed in comparison to the closure of most of the European gates to the refugees coming from the Arab world and Africa since 2015. The clear racist prioritization, distinguishing between life seekers on the basis of color, religion and ethnicity is abhorrent, but unlikely to change very soon. Some European leaders are not even ashamed to broadcast their racism publicly [as does](#) the Bulgarian Prime Minister, Kiril Petkov: “These [the Ukrainian refugees] are not the refugees we are used to ... these people are Europeans. These people are intelligent, they are educated people. ... This is not the refugee wave we have been used to, people we were not sure about their identity, people with unclear pasts, who could have been even terrorists...”

He is not alone. The Western media talks about “our kind of refugees” all the time, and this racism is manifested clearly on the border crossings between the Ukraine and its European neighbours. This racist attitude, with strong Islamophobic undertones, is not going to change, since the European leadership is still denying the multi-ethnic and multicultural fabric of societies all over the continent. A human reality created by years of European colonialism and imperialism that the current European governments deny and ignore and, at the same time, these governments pursue immigration policies that are based on the very same racism that permeated the colonialism and imperialism of the past.

Lesson Two: You Can Invade Iraq but not the Ukraine

The Western media’s unwillingness to contextualize the Russian decision to invade within a wider—and obvious—analysis of how the rules of the international game changed in 2003 is quite bewildering. It is difficult to find any analysis that points to the fact that the US and Britain violated international law on a state’s sovereignty when their armies, with a coalition of Western countries, invaded Afghanistan and Iraq. Occupying a whole country for the sake of political ends was not invented in this century by Vladimir Putin; it was introduced as a justified tool of policy by the West.

Lesson Three: Sometimes Neo-Nazism Can Be Tolerated

The analysis also fails to highlight some of Putin’s valid points about the Ukraine; which by no means justify the invasion, but need our attention even during the invasion. Up to the present crisis, the progressive Western media outlets, such as *The Nation*, the *Guardian*, the *Washington Post* etc., warned us about the growing power of neo-Nazi groups in the Ukraine that could impact the future of Europe and beyond. The same outlets today dismiss the significance of neo-Nazism in the Ukraine.

The Nation on February 22, 2019 reported: “Today, increasing reports of far-right violence, ultra nationalism and erosion of basic freedoms are giving the lie to the West’s initial euphoria. There are neo-Nazi pogroms against the Roma, rampant attacks on feminists and LGBT groups, book bans, and state-sponsored glorification of Nazi collaborators.”

Two years earlier, the *Washington Post* (June 15, 2017) warned, very perceptively, that a Ukrainian clash with Russia should not allow us to forget about the power of neo-Nazism in the Ukraine: “As Ukraine’s fight against Russian-supported separatists continues, Kiev faces another threat to its long-term sovereignty: powerful right-wing ultra-nationalist groups. These groups are not shy about using violence to achieve their goals, which are certainly at odds with the tolerant Western-oriented democracy Kiev ostensibly seeks to become.”

However, today, the *Washington Post* adopts a dismissive attitude and calls such a description as a “false accusation”: “Operating in Ukraine are several nationalist paramilitary groups, such as the Azov movement and Right Sector, that espouse neo-Nazi ideology. While high-profile, they appear to have little public support. Only one far-right party, Svoboda, is represented in Ukraine’s parliament, and only holds one seat.”

The previous warnings of an outlet such as *The Hill* (November 9, 2017), the largest independent news site in the USA, are forgotten:

“There are, indeed, neo-Nazi formations in Ukraine. This has been overwhelmingly confirmed by nearly every major Western outlet. The fact that

analysts are able to dismiss it as propaganda disseminated by Moscow is profoundly disturbing. It is especially disturbing given the current surge of neo-Nazis and white supremacists across the globe.”

Lesson Four: Hitting High-rises is only a War Crime in Europe

The Ukrainian establishment does not only have a connection with these neo-Nazi groups and armies, it is also disturbingly and embarrassingly pro-Israeli. One of President Volodymyr Zelensky’s first acts was to withdraw the Ukraine from the United Nations Committee on the Exercise of the Inalienable Rights of the Palestinian People—the only international tribunal that makes sure the Nakba is not denied or forgotten.

The decision was initiated by the Ukrainian President; he had no sympathy for the plight of the Palestinian refugees, nor did he consider them to be victims of any crime. In his interviews after the last barbaric Israeli bombardment of the Gaza Strip in May 2021, he [stated](#) that the only tragedy in Gaza was the one suffered by the Israelis. If this is so, then it is only the Russians who suffer in the Ukraine.

But Zelensky is not alone. When it comes to Palestine, the hypocrisy reaches a new level. One empty high-rise hit in the Ukraine dominated the news and prompted deep analysis about human brutality, Putin and inhumanity. These bombings should be condemned, of course, but it seems that those leading the condemnation among world leaders were silent when Israel flattened the town of Jenin in 2000, the Al-Dahaya neighborhood in Beirut in 2006 and the city of Gaza in one brutal wave after the other, over the past fifteen years. No sanctions, whatsoever, were even discussed, let alone imposed, on Israel for its war crimes in 1948 and ever since. In fact, in most of the Western countries which are leading the sanctions against Russia today, even mentioning the possibility of imposing sanctions against Israel is illegal and framed as anti-Semitic.

Even when genuine human solidarity in the West is justly expressed with the Ukraine, we cannot overlook its racist context and Europe-centric bias. The massive solidarity of the West is reserved for whoever is willing to join its bloc and sphere of influence. This official empathy is nowhere to be found when similar, and worse, violence is directed against non-Europeans, in general, and towards the Palestinians, in particular.

We can navigate as conscientious persons between our responses to calamities and our responsibility to point out hypocrisy that in many ways paved the way for such catastrophes. Legitimizing internationally the invasion of sovereign countries and licensing the continued colonization and oppression of others, such as Palestine and its people, will lead to more tragedies, such as the Ukrainian one, in the future, and everywhere on our planet.

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The Costs of (Another) War: When We Could Be Fighting Climate Change

ANDREA MAZZARINO

What do a six-year-old in the United States and an 85-year-old in Russia have in common besides being on opposite sides of a war?

They’re both feeling the strain of a warming planet.

“Is the earth going to get so hot that we can’t survive?” my young son asked me last summer as we plodded through the woods behind our Maryland home. I wasn’t certain, I replied hesitantly. (Not exactly the most reassuring answer from a mother to a question I ask myself every day.) We had just left my younger child at home, because she started wheezing when she stepped into that already more than 100-degree July morning.

A few summers earlier, during a visit to a town about 4,500 miles away near St. Petersburg, Russia, an elderly friend of mine said to me, “When did it become so hot?” Like my daughter, she was breathing hard and continually glancing back toward her doorway.

Since the 1990s, as an anthropologist of human rights and war, I’ve traveled to Russia. I was then visiting the farm where my friend grew crops to add to the food she purchased with a government stipend she got as a survivor of the Nazis’ siege of her city during World War II. She gestured towards the apples in her orchard and shook her head. Canned each fall, they provided part of her diet, but fewer of them seemed to be growing each year. Would she die of hunger and heat, I wondered, after surviving a war?

Usually, when I brought up my worries about our warming climate, she would just joke. “We could use a little global warming in Russia,” she would say and gesture at the icicle-laced landscape around her wooden home. I often heard some version of that satirical refrain in cities across Russia where, in winter, the air can grow so cold it stings your lungs.

On that last visit of mine, however, it was clear that both the frost and the heat were becoming ever more severe and unpredictable. Among acquaintances and activist colleagues alike, I found a growing awareness of environmental issues like deforestation and water pollution. But they were careful in what they said, since Russian nongovernmental organizations regularly faced threats and even politically motivated charges that could force them to close.

Still, across Russia, I had also seen examples of local authorities listening to such activists and sometimes making small changes like halting logging projects to protect a community’s food supplies or stopping construction that’s polluting local wells. And increasingly, climate change was growing harder even for Russia’s autocratic president, Vladimir Putin, to ignore, with Siberia recently all too literally on fire and its melting permafrost creating a “methane time bomb” of greenhouse gases that will help drive heating globally in a potentially disastrous way.

The Environmental Costs of War

It seems ironic, though not exactly surprising, that, by invading Ukraine last month, yet another leader who claims to care about humanity's future started a new war (just what we needed!) on this planet. And that decision has left me haunted by images of climate change at war—the exhaust emanating from the back-to-back traffic of those driving away from Ukrainian cities like Kyiv, as millions of civilians continue to flee the devastating bombardments of the Russian military. Or think of the smoke above the military base in western Ukraine that Russia attacked or the footage of the desperate residents of the besieged port city of Mariupol burning firewood to stay warm.

In 2011, I helped found Brown University's Costs of War Project, which took on the task of tracking first the human and financial costs of the American global war on terror and now of armed conflicts like the one currently unfolding in Ukraine. As that Russian invasion continues so disastrously, what should be obvious to all of us is that any war will only further exacerbate another killer on this planet—and that killer, of course, is climate change.

We started the Costs of War Project exactly because the true casualties and financial costs of armed conflict are notoriously difficult to calculate, given deliberate government obfuscation, not to speak of the chaos of battle. But there's another cost that's becoming all too clear, one we need to recognize. Consider the massive amounts of energy expended to fly fighter jets, or fire missiles, or move and supply soldiers, or send a convoy of tanks toward Kyiv. All of that, devastating in itself, now also becomes part of another war entirely, the human war that's heating this planet and already affecting ever more of its nearly eight billion inhabitants.

Modern warfare, after all, is disturbingly energy-intensive. Consider just a single mission in 2017 when two U.S. B2-B Stealth Bombers flew about 12,000 miles to strike Islamic State targets in Libya. They alone emitted about 1,000 metric tons of greenhouse gases. Consider this as well: we know that the U.S. military's greenhouse gas emissions annually are larger than those of countries like Denmark, Portugal, and Sweden. And forget the Russians for a moment: the U.S. still has military operations in more than 85 countries (and counting!).

Worse yet, fighting a war means diverting energy and resources to killing rather than to sustainable development. Countries involved, even peripherally, in such conflicts are likely to have a far more limited capacity to deal with that other war, the environmental one. Take, for example, Italy and Germany in the wake of the invasion of Ukraine. Faced with the need to replace natural gas and other fuel delivered from Russia, Italy now has provisional plans to reopen previously shut coal plants; while Germany, faced with an even greater energy crisis without Russian energy supplies, may now delay plans to close its last coal plants until 2030. Both of those are small climate disasters. Obviously, there's no way of imagining when Ukraine's cities will be able to deal with climate change again. The now-destroyed Mariupol is a prime example. Once labeled by the European Bank of Reconstruction and Development's Green Cities Program as one of the most "engaged" cities for its efforts to invest in renewable energy and clean up water pollution, it's now in a desperate struggle for its own survival.

Similarly, according to the Conflict and Environment Observatory, since the start of the war between Ukraine's military and Russian-backed separatists in

the Donbas region in 2014, the main power plant there has had to use reserves of low-grade, high-polluting fuel. The higher-grade kind once supplied by the central government of Ukraine is no longer available. Other impacts of this war and wars like it include clear-cutting forests to house refugees and powering camps with gas generators. Makeshift, hazardous methods of waste disposal like U.S. burn pits on military bases in Iraq were another example of the environmentally destructive methods so often sanctioned under war conditions.

The U.S. and Its Climate Inaction

Lately, headlines warning of environmental catastrophe have been thoroughly displaced (to the extent they even existed) by headlines about war. We're all talking about the possibility of a World War III, but there are far too few conversations about the climate impact of the military buildup already affecting Europe so radically.

Consider it typical of our moment (and U.N. Secretary-General António Guterres the exception) that President Biden essentially skipped climate change in his State of the Union address, even as he drew bipartisan applause for calling on Americans to unite in support of Ukraine. A wildly scaled-down version of his Build Back Better spending bill that might once have channeled \$3.5 trillion towards investment in social services and clean energy didn't even muster sufficient votes in his own party to make it through the Senate. (Thank you, coal magnate Joe Manchin!)

Yet just two weeks into the war between Russia and Ukraine, a bipartisan Senate voted 68-31 on a \$1.5 trillion government spending bill that authorized \$13.6 billion in military and humanitarian aid for Ukraine. The package includes sending tens of thousands of U.S. troops to NATO countries, paying for the \$350 million in weaponry this country has already sent to the Ukrainian military, our intelligence aid to that country, and money to help enforce sanctions against Russia. And it's clear that the spigot has just been turned on. The Biden administration added another \$800 million in weapons and protective gear for Ukraine's military by week three of the war. Most recently, it committed \$1 billion more to assist European countries in accepting Ukrainian refugees, while vowing to admit 100,000 Ukrainian refugees to U.S. soil.

The human costs of war, of course, continue to unfold day by day as parts of Ukraine are destroyed and thousands of people on both sides are killed in the fighting, though estimates of the numbers vary widely. That's part of the problem. Calculating war's true costs takes many years, while even before the smoke clears another war, an environmental one whose casualties will, in the long run, be staggering, is gearing up, barely noticed by so many.

Environmental Carnage, Then and Now

Climate change is affecting peoples' health, the natural environment, and our infrastructure everywhere. According to the U.N. Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change's latest report, these effects, including intensifying extreme weather, a greater frequency and spread of diseases, severe future water shortages for roughly half the global population annually, and more frequent flooding and droughts, were intensifying even before the latest war began.

Scientists say that, given the world's current rate of energy consumption and the temperature change that accompanies it, we should by 2100 expect outcomes of this sort: a five-fold increase in extreme weather events like flooding or wildfires; a leap in the percentage of the global population exposed to deadly heat stress from 48% to 76%; more than a billion coastal inhabitants adversely affected by rising seas and other climate risks by mid-century; and 183 million additional malnourished people by then.

Somewhere in this flood of bad climate news, however, there may prove to be a strange silver lining: such a range of potential climate crises that pay no attention to borders should ultimately have the potential to connect us to our geopolitical enemies (though this seems even less likely than it did when the Ukraine war began, now that Putin's climate envoy has resigned in protest). The development of climate diplomacy has never been more urgent, since without collective action aimed at creating a carbon-neutral world by 2050, we'll all lose this fight.

In 2010, I took a four-day train trip from St. Petersburg, Russia, to the Krasnodar region near Ukraine, for a friend's wedding. The heat that July was already stifling. Drought had led to wildfires that were sweeping across European Russia, blanketing Moscow in putrid smoke and reportedly resulting in tens of thousands of excess deaths from various causes related to heat, pollution, and the fires themselves.

Like me, other passengers opened the windows of our sleeper cars for a breeze only to find the air so smoky it covered our faces in soot within minutes. At one point, a group of new Russian army recruits, skinny adolescents with acne cratering their faces, boarded my car. They joked about how the air made them feel like they'd been smoking all day, when they were trying not to so that they could carry out whatever mission lay ahead of them in Russia's conflict-ridden borderlands. (Putin's crew was then fighting a counterinsurgency war in nearby Chechnya.) The soldiers scraped together their spare change and insisted on preparing meals for us all to share from goods purchased in outdoor markets where the train made stops.

During that trip 12 years ago, it already felt as though something was changing in terms of Russia's relationship to the world. It was becoming harder for journalists to write critically about the government, particularly its military. Luxury restaurants, car dealerships, and cosmetics stores were popping up, yet ordinary Russians were still struggling to make ends meet.

As that train stopped in small towns, grandmothers and children holding paper trays of homemade chicken cutlets and cucumbers for passengers to buy looked so much more wind-worn and soot-covered than we did. At one stop, a policeman in his fifties, with his wife and two kids, heading home to Chechnya, joined me in my cabin. They'd been on vacation in Crimea, which Ukraine still controlled then. "Did you know that it had once belonged to Russia?" he asked me. It was easier, he added, for his family to go there when he was a kid and Ukraine was still a part of the Soviet Union, but it was beautiful and I should visit. He and his wife took turns wiping their children's sooty faces with wet washcloths. "My God, when did this heat get so bad?" he asked not exactly me, but the air, the planet.

And it's true, I've never forgotten the heat that enveloped us all then and my early sense of our shared humanity in the face of a changing climate. Of course,

as anyone in the American West who experienced the record fires, heat domes, and megadrought of the last year knows, it's only been getting worse.

As different as our all-too-fragile democracy still thankfully is from Russia's autocracy, what we do have in common is short-sightedness. It causes the political class in both countries to focus on military solutions—remember the disastrous Global War on Terror?—to geopolitical problems with deep historical roots. What if we had marshaled the support of intermediaries like Finland or Israel back when Volodymyr Zelensky first reached out to Putin upon taking office as Ukraine's president in 2019? What if long ago Washington had declared that Ukraine would never be a candidate for membership in NATO? Perhaps today its president wouldn't be pleading for a NATO no-fly zone that could take the world to the existential edge of nuclear war.

What might still make a difference would be nonviolent, diplomatic steps to protect the victims of this war, paving the way for diplomacy to triumph over militarism and sustainable development over destruction. It makes me sick to my stomach that the window to act is closing for the people I love, near and far. Not just the horrific killing and destruction of the moment, but the long-term suffering likely to come from the environmental damage we're causing should impel us all to call for a major diplomatic push to end the nightmare in Ukraine now. After all, if the world's great powers don't pull together soon on climate action, we're in deep trouble.

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Escalating the War in Ukraine Means a Global Race to Catastrophe

FARAMARZ FARBOD

“Ukrainians,” in the words of Ben Wallace, the British Defense Secretary, “are fighting for their very lives and they are fighting for our freedoms.” “Ukraine’s success,” the White House stated, “is central to the global struggle between democracy and autocracy.” The Russian invasion of Ukraine was “unprovoked” and proves that Putin is intent on brutally reconstructing the Russian empire. That is what the western media, politicians, and the subservient intellectuals who serve them, tell us. What this simplistic binary narrative of a good western-backed democratic Ukraine against an evil Putin-led autocratic Russia obscures are the imperial interests of the US, the US role in creating the conditions without which the Russian invasion of Ukraine could not have happened, and the US role in prolonging the war at the expense of Ukrainians first and foremost, but not only them. Anyone daring to utter a contrary narrative is dismissed as Putin’s apologist and a useful idiot at best or banned at worse.

The western propaganda narrative uses the term “unprovoked” every time it mentions Russian invasion of Ukraine. This is to prevent opening a Pandora’s box of critical appraisals of how the world works. It is an example of narrative management by the chattering classes aimed at reducing or removing the cost of democracy for empire. So, was the Russian invasion of Ukraine ‘unprovoked’ as the western media and intellectuals repeat *ad nauseum*? To answer this question, we need to keep in mind several key historical events that are kept out of the official account of the war in Ukraine, events that are dismissed as irrelevant or Russian talking points.

The US adopts a winner-take-all policy after the collapse of the USSR and the end of the bipolar world order that had characterized it. This in spite of extensive security assurances against NATO’s expansion eastward to the USSR by the highest-ranking western officials. They promised NATO would not move an inch eastward in exchange for the USSR agreeing to a unified Germany joining NATO. But not expanding NATO was not an option even after the demise of the Warsaw Pact and a chance for a durable US-Russia strategic partnership was lost. The arrogant triumphalism of the period had led intellectuals to declare “the end of history” and the final victory of liberal capitalism over all its historical challengers. The imperial US managers understood well the opportunity that this “unipolar moment” had presented them but needed a new rationale to continue expanding US global dominance. The neoconservative policy advisers to Dick Cheney, Bush Sr.’s defense secretary, did just that. They wrote the Pentagon’s new “Defense Planning Guidance” for the coming period. *The New York Times* reported it, and though it was dismissed at first for its brazenness, it reflected the imperial mindset of the US planners.

The document asserts that the new world order is ultimately backed by the US who must never allow any other power or combination of powers in any region of the world to even consider challenging its military predominance. The leaders of this lone

superpower “must maintain the mechanisms for deterring potential competitors from even aspiring to a larger regional or global role.” This required a vastly increased military spending, bolstering regional alliances, and an expanding commitment to ex-Warsaw Pact states in Eastern Europe, among other requirements.

The first wave of NATO’s expansion eastward followed in 1997, the next in 2004, and then came its (read the US’s) announcement in 2008, notwithstanding the German and French objection, that it would bring Georgia and Ukraine into its fold in the future thereby indicating the intention to take NATO’s expansion right up to Russia’s borders. Russia made it clear that Georgia and Ukraine were its red lines.

Pressure to make Ukraine the epicenter of the new Cold War had been growing. “I used to say that if Ukraine is suborned by Russia, which I now think is less likely, Russia again becomes an empire,” said Zbigniew Brzezinski, the former US National Security Advisor to President Carter, in 2011. “But now I think even further, that if Ukraine is not suborned, Russia is much more likely to become European.”

An opportunity to make Ukraine a de facto member of NATO presented itself in 2014. In that year, demonstrations that had erupted in Ukraine late in 2013 ended up toppling the government that had favored a pro-neutrality stance between the EU and Russia. The US backed this coup, which included a role played by neo-Nazi forces. The coup led to the rise of ultra nationalist, pro-west/NATO, and anti-Russian politics with Kyiv embarking on harsh policies against the Russian-speaking Ukrainians living in the eastern provinces of Donbas. Russia subsequently annexed Crimea and backed the two regions of Donbas proclaiming themselves as separate republics. An eight-year long civil war ensued between the government in Kyiv and the two Russia-backed separatist republics. It took the lives of some 14,000 people, 80% of whom were Russian-speaking people from the Donbas region, and displaced perhaps two million people. The US supported Kyiv militarily, especially since 2017, pouring in arms and training, including the neo-Nazis who had been integrated into the Ukrainian armed forces. In 2015, Germany, France, Russia and Ukraine signed the Minsk II agreement to resolve the civil war by giving the separatist republics in the east significant autonomy in a federated constitutional arrangement. President Zelensky was elected in 2019 promising to implement this and visited the region but faced death threats from the ultra-nationalists and neo-Nazis. The US failed to support him on this and Minsk II continued to be ignored.

In June 2020, the North Atlantic Council recognized Ukraine as an Enhanced Opportunities Partner, a part of NATO’s Partnership Interoperability Initiative, “which aims to maintain and deepen cooperation between Allies and partners that have made significant contributions to NATO-led operations and missions. As a NATO partner, Ukraine has provided troops to Allied operations, including in Afghanistan and Kosovo, as well as to the NATO Response Force and NATO exercises.” This makes Ukraine one of six such partners. Others are Australia, Finland, Georgia, Jordan, and Sweden.

In September 2021, President Biden’s White House released a Joint Statement on US-Ukraine Strategic Partnership. In a section titled “Deepening Strategic Defense Cooperation”, it states: “The United States and Ukraine have finalized a Strategic Defense Framework that creates a foundation for the enhancement of U.S.-Ukraine strategic defense and security cooperation and the advancement of shared

priorities, including implementing defense and defense industry reforms, deepening cooperation in areas such as Black Sea security, cyber defense, and intelligence sharing, and countering Russian aggression.” It continues: “We intend to continue our robust training and exercise program in keeping with Ukraine’s status as a NATO Enhanced Opportunities Partner. Ukraine plans to continue taking steps to... modernize its defense acquisition process to advance its Euro-Atlantic aspirations.”

The US had also twice rejected Russia’s suggestions in the 1990s to join NATO, which raises the following questions? Can an offensive and violent military alliance, not a defensive alliance as NATO describes itself, exist with Russia as a partner or member? Clearly the answer is no. And: Can the US maintain its hegemony over Europe without a NATO? Here too, the answer is no. A key aim of the US is to prevent the rise of an independent Europe. NATO is critical to this project. Its function, as some observers suggest, is to keep Germany down, Russia out, and US dominant. (I would also add: to prevent the rise of an independent Eurasia, i.e. independent of US influence.) Since the invasion, western media dismiss NATO’s expansion as irrelevant at best and Russian state propaganda at worse. Forgotten are statements by several top US diplomats warning against the process of expanding NATO eastward to include Ukraine and Georgia with clear understanding that including them in the offensive military alliance targeting Russia will have dangerous ramifications. Among these officials were President Biden (a Senator during the late 1990s), Director of CIA William Burns (then US ambassador to Russia from 2005 to 2008), Henry Kissinger, George Kennan the architect of the Cold War, and Jack F. Matlock Jr. the US ambassador to the USSR from 1987 to 1991.

In an article published in mid-February, a week before the Russian invasion of Ukraine, Matlock described the current crisis as “predictable, willfully precipitated,” and one that could easily have been “resolved by the application of common sense,” since Putin was seeking assurances that NATO not expand to include Ukraine and Georgia and the Donbas provinces be incorporated into Ukraine with a large degree of autonomy and full citizenship rights for their inhabitants. He argued that “obviously there would have been no basis for the present crisis if there had been no expansion of the alliance following the end of the Cold War, or if the expansion had occurred in harmony with building a security structure in Europe that included Russia.”

Matlock came to this view long before Russia invaded Ukraine. As someone who had participated in the negotiations that ended the Cold War, he testified in a 1997 Senate Foreign Relations Committee against the recommendation to inaugurate a process of NATO expansion eastward. He called it “misguided” and said that “it may well go down in history as the most profound strategic blunder made since the end of the Cold War. Far from improving the security of the United States, its Allies, and the nations that wish to enter the Alliance, it could well encourage a chain of events that could produce the most serious security threat to this nation since the Soviet Union collapsed.” He added, in his recent article, that “Indeed, our nuclear arsenals were capable of ending the possibility of civilization on Earth.”

It’s clear that the US no longer respects red lines as it did during the Cold War with the USSR. Now only the US can have red lines that no power can cross. The US can expand a violent and offensive military alliance right up to Russia’s borders, exclude it from the post-Cold War European security order, interfere in the internal

affairs of Ukraine, turn it into a de facto NATO member, enter into strategic defense cooperation with it, send billions of dollars of military aid and train its armed forces, and dismiss any claim that Russia may have legitimate national security concerns at all.

In sum, the western claim that the Russian invasion of Ukraine was “unprovoked” is laughable and hypocritical. The US invasion and occupation of Iraq was an unprovoked invasion, to take but one example. And no one to date has been punished for that atrocity, except those few who had exposed its criminality, like Julian Assange.

Another neglected aspect of the current crisis in Ukraine is the global crisis of cost of living stemming from the western sanctions imposed on Russia and the normal operations of capitalist markets globally. Millions of the most vulnerable people in the world will suffer hardships caused by disruptions of supplies of basic foods and fuel and the heightened inflationary pressures. Russia and Ukraine are major exporters of cereal grains, cooking oils, fuel and fertilizers. Many countries, including those in the low-income-and-food-deficit category, depend on importing such goods.

The World Bank warns that the war is set to cause the “largest commodity shock” in 50 years, with price hikes impacting goods ranging from fuels to basic foods. The most disruptive impact will be on the poorest nations, communities, and households. It estimates that energy prices will go up by more than 50% in spite of the fact that from April 2020 to March 2022 we had witnessed “the largest 23-month increase in energy prices since the 1973 oil price hike.” The UN too has warned that food prices are “at their highest since records began 60 years ago” with “nearly 13%” jump in March alone, “following February’s record high.” It estimated that if the war persists “the global number of undernourished people could increase by 8 to 13 million people in 2022/23, with the most pronounced increases taking place in Asia-Pacific, followed by sub-Saharan Africa, and the Near East and North Africa.” The current crisis in Ukraine adds to the food insecurity crisis stemming from the COVID-19 pandemic and environmental disruptions. Up to 811 million people had faced hunger in 2020 and millions more had been added since due to the pandemic. The most vulnerable will suffer in other ways too. For example, the UN also points out that “the World Bank has estimated that in Central Asian countries which are highly dependent on remittances from workers in Russia (such as 31% of GDP in Kyrgyz Republic and 27% of GDP in Tajikistan), remittances could decline 25% on average.”

The oligarchs in the US and Ukraine however will vastly enrich themselves. The disruption of supplies, the price hikes, and the massive increases in military sales, transfers, and spending present them with opportunities to do just that – especially well placed are the giant multinational corporations in the energy, military, and agricultural sectors. The CEO’s of these corporations are giddy with joy and popping open bottles of Champaign in anticipation of coming super profits. One example from the agricultural sector shall suffice here: Archer Daniels Midland, a US firm and one of the four big food commodity traders in the world, reports that its net earnings for the 1st quarter of 2022 has increased by 53% (to \$1.05bn). Its CEO anticipates further price hikes and even higher earnings in the months to come. As for the Ukrainian oligarchs, it’s safe to assume that they’re enriching themselves with the US taxpayer’s money that’s flowing to their country. It’s likely that reports of the vast increase in their wealth holdings will surface once the fog of war subsides.

It's in the nature of the capitalist organization of global order that as tens of millions of the most vulnerable among us suffer hardship and hunger due to natural or human-made disasters a handful of ultra-rich individuals and corporations will reap super profits. A rational or humane organization of society would distribute scarce resources on the basis of need not greed or money.

What about the risk of nuclear war? Is it a hyperbole to think of the unthinkable at this moment? The US has stated that its policy is to weaken Russia, not to end the war or save Ukraine from further destruction. It's also clear that Washington prefers a sober Boris Yeltsin figure over Putin, though it denies that regime change is its objective. But how will the US implement a policy aimed at reducing the power of Russia to a level that would prevent it from claiming a regional power status, not to say of removing Putin from power? Will the US count on waging a long-term proxy war against Russia at the expense of the last Ukrainian? Aren't we dealing with two sides that cannot accept defeat? The US and its allies have announced Ukraine will win; and Russia is very unlikely to give up the eastern Donbas provinces and cease its military operations no matter how much US and NATO military aid pours into Ukraine. (The Biden administration has asked Congress to approve \$33bn in aid for Ukraine, \$20.5bn of which is for the military, in addition to \$13.6bn it had approved earlier, \$3.7bn of which was military aid.)

Consider also that the US has managed in the past two decades to dismantle the architecture of the nuclear arms control. It withdrew from the ABM and the INF treaties in 2002 and 2019, respectively. By doing so, it signaled to Russia that it was not averse to placing advanced nuclear weaponry ever closer to its borders. That's insanity on par with ignoring the looming ecological catastrophe.

Russia's Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov recently warned the west to take the risk of nuclear war seriously. "This is our key position on which we base everything," he stated referring to Russia striving to prevent nuclear war at all costs. "The risks now are considerable," he said. "I would not want to elevate those risks artificially. Many would like that. The danger is serious, real. And we must not underestimate it." The US Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin's response to Lavrov was not reassuring either. He stated that such "saber rattling" rhetoric was "very dangerous and unhelpful" and that "Nobody wants to see a nuclear war happen. It's a war where all sides lose." On the other hand, he was talking "after hosting defense talks at Ramstein Air Base involving more than 40 countries seeking to speed and synchronize supply of weapons to Kyiv." When asked about his recent comments that the US seeks to "weaken" Russia, he did not back down: "We do want to make it harder for Russia to threaten its neighbors and leave them less able to do that." The Pentagon chief also said "Ukraine clearly believes that it can win, and so does everyone here," and this: "we're going to keep on moving heaven and earth to meet" Ukraine's near-term security requirements. He had also stated that the US is "ready for anything."

It's possible to imagine scenarios that lead to more perilous outcomes. For instance, how would Putin respond to attacks targeting sites inside Russia? How would he react if he feels that he is threatened or has no exit or that Russia is threatened? What if, as others have suggested, the US were to place hypersonic non-nuclear missiles with decapitation strike capabilities in Poland and Romania. Such weapons can strike leadership targets in Moscow within 5–7 minutes. Will Putin not respond?

Even if he does not react, Russian nuclear doctrine emphasizes launch on warning as soon as they get an indication of such a strike. Is five minutes sufficient for Russia to determine whether a decapitation strike is under way when it may be a false indication, a human or technological error?

A policy of weakening Russia has other complications. It may push Russia in the arms of China creating an "antihegemonic bloc" opposed to the United States, perhaps with other countries joining them, like Iran. How would this scenario serve the US interests? It doesn't, unless we assume that the US grand strategy is to encircle China after weakening Russia. Isn't that the intent of the policy of 'pivot to Asia' involving shifting imperial resources to east Asia, increasing pressure on China using Taiwan, Hong Kong, and the Korean Peninsula, and building an expanded alliance with Japan and Australia?

In short, unless Washington is confident that a weakened Putin accepts defeat or is somehow removed from power soon, or that talking about weakening Russia is just hubris, then winning the war at all cost, escalating, and blocking diplomacy are recipes for disastrous outcomes.

There is no oppositional political formation anywhere in the US that can challenge the post-Cold War US imperial policies. The US left too is inconsequential in US politics to demand anything. This is a depressing fact at a time when US planners and their western allies are welcoming a return to "a period of systemic competition," in the words of the British Armed Forces Minister Heappey. The left should nevertheless make its positions clear. It should demand an immediate ceasefire, an end to the flow of weapons to Ukraine, a negotiated settlement on the basis of Ukraine's neutrality, and, if possible, the incorporation of the eastern Donbas provinces into Ukraine with full rights for all within a federated system.

Beyond these immediate and necessary demands, the left ought to combat the perception that the end of the USSR meant the end of the danger of nuclear threat and insist that the US return to nuclear arms control treaties. It should also demand that the US establish a common European security arrangement that includes Russia as an equal partner and call for dismantling NATO altogether. Clearly, NATO does not increase security; as a violent and offensive military alliance it does the opposite, and has now led to a war.

Lastly, the left should continue to oppose the weaponization of human rights discourses and the rank hypocrisy of treating only the victims of adversarial states as worthy of attention while ignoring the vastly larger number of victims of western imperial policies; condemn the systematic racism in the treatment of non-European refugees from wars waged by western powers compared to the European refugees from Ukraine; oppose the hyper military spending stemming from the crisis in Ukraine; and fight the emerging McCarthyism 2.0 aimed at censoring and banishing dissident voices and sources that counter the official narrative of the state.

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Coxey's Army: The First "Occupiers"

LENNY FLANK

In 1893, the "Financial Panic" gripped the United States as the economy fell into recession and the ranks of the unemployed and homeless swelled. In response, an organized group of people from all over the US converged on Washington DC to protest against income inequality and to demand that Congress pass a jobs bill, and vowed to camp out in front of the Capitol Building for as long as necessary until their demands were met. It was the first "Occupy" movement in the US, and it was led by a man named Jacob Coxey.

By 1890, the US had mostly recovered from the economic shock of the Financial Panic of 1873. The Spanish-American War had kick-started the economy, the railroads were steadily expanding across the US, settlers and homesteaders were pouring into the conquered West, and the economy was booming.

But the good times did not last long. In 1893, the wheat harvest in Argentina (in which American investors were heavily involved) was a disaster, causing a financial shock that rippled through Wall Street, and was compounded by over-investment in railroads and falling prices for silver and gold. The result was the Panic of 1893, the worst depression in US history up to that time. Unemployment in the US swelled to over 10 percent, eventually reaching 18 percent. Homeless people crowded into every city, and thousands were arrested and jailed for "vagrancy". Popular resentment at the Gilded Age wealthy reached explosive proportions.

Then a little-known businessman in Ohio named Jacob Coxey, who owned a local sand quarry, proposed what was at the time a breathtakingly radical solution--the US Government should offer jobs to the unemployed by using them to expand and repair the nation's roads network. In the 1930's, Franklin D Roosevelt would propose the very same idea to deal with another Depression, but in 1893 the US was in love with laissez-faire "free market" economic ideology, and the very idea that the Federal Government should involve itself with economic policy or help the unemployed in any way was akin to socialist propaganda. Coxey knew that his proposal would never be acted on by Congress. So, working together with a labor union organizer from San Francisco named Carl Browne, Coxey formed a plan to organize a massive protest, an "army of the unemployed", to march on Washington DC and force Congress to pass the "Good Roads Bill" providing \$500 million in funding for a massive infrastructure-building jobs program. "Congress takes two years to vote on anything," Coxey announced. "Twenty-millions of people are hungry and cannot wait two years to eat."

Browne, the labor union leader, was an odd character--he often wore fringed buckskin suits, made incomprehensible speeches about religion and ghosts, and declared that he was a reincarnation of Jesus Christ (and promptly announced that Coxey himself was a reincarnation of President Andrew Jackson). But he was a skillful organizer, and within months, word of "Coxey's Army" had spread across the

country. On March 25, 1894, Easter Sunday, Coxey left Massillon, Ohio, at the head of about 100 unemployed people, bound for Washington DC.

All across the US, in a wave of protest, similar groups formed, from San Francisco to Florida. The West, where the recession had hit particularly hard, was particularly enthusiastic: in several incidents, groups of unemployed people hopped on trains to make their way to Washington DC. In Texas, a Southern Pacific Railroad train stopped on the tracks, uncoupled the car containing 500 protesters, and chugged off, leaving them stranded in the middle of the desert. Unemployed railroad workers in Montana, on the other hand, stole an entire train to get themselves to DC: they managed to go almost 350 miles before the train was stopped by Federal Marshals. Press reports of the chase inspired others, and some 50 trains were commandeered by people on their way to join "Coxey's Army". Small groups set out from all over the country to converge at the Capitol Building, with each one swelling in numbers as they passed through towns and cities and recruited new followers. Thousands of people greeted the marchers as they passed through town, listening to speeches and providing the protesters with food and places to sleep. The "Army" contained both men and women, of all races. Estimates of the total number of marchers range as high as 20,000. Their rhetoric steadily grew, from simply proposing a jobs bill to demands for redistribution of wealth, labor law reforms, and social justice and equality. Red flags began to appear. The press made it a front-page story across the United States.

It was enough to scare the living daylights out of the Gilded Age super-rich. Fearing that the class war was about to break out again (the Paris Commune in France and the Great Railroad Rebellion in the US had been less than 20 years ago), the wealthy East Coast elite ran in terror to the Federal Government and begged for protection. New York City and Chicago banned any public protest gatherings. Local militia troops attacked and burned a Coxeyite camp outside of Washington DC. Most of the protest groups crossing the country towards Washington DC instead ended up in jail, or were forcibly dispersed with billy clubs and dumped onto trains for California or Arizona to get rid of them. When the day of the planned gathering at the Capitol came, May 1, 1894, only a few thousand of the protesters had made it. About 500 of "Coxey's Army" entered Washington DC with Coxey and his daughter Mamie (dressed in white robes as "The Goddess of Peace") at their head. They camped on the front lawn of the Capitol Building, with another 3-4,000 protesters still just a day or two's walk away, and declared that they would stay there until Congress acted.

Coxey stood on the Capitol steps and unfolded his written speech asking for a jobs bill. He never got to give it. The protesters were surrounded by over a thousand police, who quickly moved in, clubbed them to the ground, and arrested the leaders (including Coxey and Browne) for "walking on the grass". Within half an hour it was over, and "Coxey's Army" had melted away. Coxey and Browne spent 20 days in jail.

In April 1935, as part of FDR's New Deal, Congress passed legislation setting up the Works Progress Administration, which provided jobs to the nation's unemployed through work on the country's road system and infrastructure. Coxey had won after all. During an FDR political rally on May 1, 1944, Coxey himself, now 90 years old, was invited to stand on the steps of the Capitol Building and give the speech he

had planned to give 50 years earlier. Part of Coxey's speech said: "We stand here to remind Congress of its promise of returning prosperity should the Sherman act be repealed. We stand here to declare by our march of over 400 miles through difficulties and distress, a march unstained by even the slightest act which would bring the blush of shame to any, that we are law-abiding citizens, and as men our actions speak louder than words. We are here to petition for legislation which will furnish employment for every man able and willing to work; for legislation which will bring universal prosperity and emancipate our beloved country from financial bondage to the descendants of King George. We have come to the only source which is competent to aid the people in their day of dire distress. We are here to tell our Representatives, who hold their seats by grace of our ballots, that the struggle for existence has become too fierce and relentless. We come and throw up our defenseless hands, and say, help, or we and our loved ones must perish. We are engaged in a bitter and cruel war with the enemies of all mankind a war with hunger, wretchedness, and despair, and we ask Congress to heed our petitions and issue for the nation's good a sufficient volume of the same kind of money which carried the country through one awful war and saved the life of the nation."

Decades later, in 2011, a group of protesters sat down in Zuccotti Park, near Wall Street, and announced that they would not leave until their demands for economic justice were met. Although few of the Occupy Wall Street participants had ever even heard of Coxey or his Army, they had unwittingly duplicated his demands and his tactics.

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Cuba Prepares for Disaster

Review of [Disaster Preparedness and Climate Change in Cuba: Adaptation and Management](#), edited by Emily J. Kirk, Isabel Story, & Anna Clayfield

DON FITZ

The [September 2021 *Scientific American*](#) included a description by the editors of the deplorable state of disaster relief in the US. They traced the root cause of problems with relief programs as their "focus on restoring private property," which results in little attention to those "with the least capacity to deal with disasters." The book *Disaster Preparedness and Climate Change in Cuba: Adaptation and Management* (2021) came out the next month. It traced the highly successful source of the island nation's efforts to the way it put human welfare above property. This collection of 14 essays by Emily J. Kirk, Isabel Story, and Anna Clayfield is an extraordinary assemblage of articles, each addressing specific issues.

Writers are well aware that Cuban approaches are adapted to the unique geography and history of the island. What readers should take away is not so much the specific actions of Cuba as its method of studying a wide array of approaches and actually putting the best into effect (as opposed to merely talking about their strengths and weaknesses). The book traces Cuba's preparedness from the threat of a US invasion following its revolution through its resistance to hurricanes and diseases, which all laid the foundation for current adaptations to climate change.

Only four years after the revolution, in 1963, Hurricane Flora hit the Caribbean, killing 7000–8000. Cubans who are old enough remember homes being washed away by waters carrying rotten food, animal carcasses, and human bodies. It sparked a complete redesign of health systems, intensifying their integration from the highest decision-making bodies to local health centers. Construction standards were strengthened, requiring houses to have reinforced concrete and metal roofs to resist strong winds.

Decades of re-designing proved successful. In September 2017, Category 5 Hurricane Maria pounded Puerto Rico, leading to 2975 deaths. The same month, Irma, also a Category 5 Hurricane, arrived in Cuba, causing 10 deaths. The dedication to actually preparing the country for a hurricane (as opposed to merely talking about preparedness) became a model for coping with climate change. Projecting potential future damage led Cubans to realize that by 2050, rising water levels could destroy 122 coastal towns. By 2017, Cuba had become the only country with a government-led plan (Project Life, or Tarea Vida) to combat climate change which includes a 100-year projection.

Disaster Planning

Several aspects merged to form the core of Cuban disaster planning. They included education, the military, and social relationships. During 1961, Cuba's signature campaign raised literacy to 96%, one of the world's highest rates. This has been

central to every aspect of disaster preparation—government officials and educators travel throughout the island, explaining the consequences of inaction and everyone's role in avoiding catastrophe.

Less obvious is the critical role of the military. From the first days they took power, leaders such as Fidel and Che explained that the only way the revolution could defend itself from overwhelming US force would be to become a “nation in arms.” Soon self-defense from hurricanes combined with self-defense from attack and Cuban armed forces became a permanent part of fighting natural disasters. By 1980, exercises called Bastión (bulwark) fused natural disaster management with defense rehearsals.

As many as 4 million Cubans (in a population of 11 million) were involved in activities to practice and carry out food production, disease control, sanitation, and the safeguarding of medical supplies. A culture based on understanding the need to create a new society has glued these actions together. When a policy change is introduced, government representatives go to each community, including the most remote rural ones, to make sure that everyone knows the threats that climate change poses to their lives and how they can alter behaviors to minimize them. Developing a sense of responsibility for ecosystems includes such diverse actions as conserving energy, saving water, preventing fires, and using medical products sparingly.

Contradictions

One aspect of the book may confuse readers. Some authors refer to the Cuban disaster prevention system as “centralized;” others refer to it as “decentralized;” and some describe it as both “centralized” and “decentralized” on different pages of their essay. The collection reflects a methodology of “dialectical materialism” which often employs the unity of opposite processes (“heads” and “tails” are opposite static states united in the concept of “coin”). As multiple authors have explained, including [Ross Danielson in his classic *Cuban Medicine* \(1979\)](#), centralization and decentralization of medicine have gone hand-in-hand since the earliest days of the revolution. This may appear as centralization of inpatient care and decentralization of outpatient care (p. 165) but more often as centralization at the highest level of norms and decentralization of ways to implement care to the local level. The decision to create doctor-nurse offices was made by the ministry which provided guidelines for each area to implement according to local conditions.

A national plan for coping with Covid-19 was developed before the first Cuban died of the affliction, and each area designed ways to get needed medicines, vaccines, and other necessities to their communities. Proposals for preventing water salinization in coastal areas will be very different from schemas for coping with rises in temperature in inland communities.

Challenges for Producing Energy: The Good

As non-stop use of fossil fuels renders the continued existence of humanity questionable, the issue of how to obtain energy rationally looms as a core problem of the twenty-first century. Disaster Preparedness explores an intriguing variety of energy sources. Some of them are outstandingly good; a few are bad; and many provoke closer examination.

Raúl Castro proposed in 1980 that it was necessary to protect the countryside from impacts of nickel mining. What was critical in this early approach was an understanding that every type of metal extraction has negatives that must be weighed against its usefulness in order to minimize those negatives. What did not appear in his approach was making a virtue of necessity, which would have read “Cuba needs nickel for trade; therefore, extracting Cuban nickel is good; and, thus, problems with producing nickel should be ignored or trivialized.”

In 1991, when the USSR collapsed and Cuba lost its subsidies and many of its trading partners, its economy was devastated, adult males lost an average of 20 pounds, and health problems became widespread. This was Cuba's “Special Period.” Not having oil meant that Cuba had to abandon machine-intensive agriculture for agroecology and urban farming.

Laws prohibited use of agrochemicals in urban gardens. Vegetable and herb production exploded from 4000 tons in 1994 to over 4 million tons by 2006. By 2019, Jason Hickel's Sustainable Development Index rated Cuba's ecological efficiency as the best in the world.

By far the most important part of Cuba's energy program was using less energy via conservation, an idea abandoned by Western “environmentalists” who began endorsing unlimited expansion of energy produced by “alternative” sources. In 2005, Fidel began pushing conservation policies projected to reduce Cuba's energy consumption by two-thirds. Ideas such these had blossomed during the first few years of the revolution.

What one author refers to as “bioclimatic architecture” is not clear, but it could include [tile vaulting, which was studied extensively](#) by the Cuban government in the early 1960s. It is based on arched ceilings formed by lightweight terra cotta tiles. The technique is low-carbon because it does not require expensive machinery and uses mainly local material such as terra cotta tiles from Camagüey province. Though used to construct buildings throughout the island, it was abandoned due to its need for skilled and specialized labor.

Challenges for Producing Energy: The Bad

Though there are negative aspects to Cuba's energy perspectives, it is important to consider one which is anything but negative: energy efficiency (EE). Ever since [Stanley Jevons predicted in 1865 that a more efficient steam engine design](#) would result in more (not less) coal being used, it has been widely understood that if the price of energy (such as burning coal) is cheaper, then people will use more energy.

A considerable amount of research verifies that, at the level of the entire economy, efficiency makes energy cheaper and its use goes up. Some claim that if an individual uses a more EE option, then that person will use less energy. But that is not necessarily so. Someone buying a car might look for one that is more EE. If the person replaces a non-EE sedan with an EE SUV, the fact that SUVs use more energy than sedans would mean that the person is using more energy to get around. Similarly, rich people use money saved from EE devices to buy more gadgets while poor people might not buy anything additional or buy low-energy necessities.

This is why Cuba, a poor country with a planned economy, can design policies to reduce energy use. Whatever is saved from EE can lead to less or low-energy production, resulting in a spiraling down of energy usage. In contrast, competition drives capitalist economies toward investing funds saved from EE toward economic expansion, resulting in perpetual growth.

Though a planned economy allows for decisions that are healthier for people and ecosystems, bad choices can be made. One consideration in Cuba is the goal to “efficiently apply pesticides” (p. 171). The focus should actually be on how to farm without pesticides. Also, under consideration is “solid waste energy capacities,” which is typically a euphemism for burning waste in incinerators. Incinerators are a terrible way to produce energy since they merely reduce the volume of trash to 10% of its original size while releasing poisonous gases, heavy metals (such as mercury and lead), and cancer-causing dioxins and furans.

The worst energy alternative was favored by Fidel, who supported a nuclear power plant which would supposedly “greatly reduce the cost of producing electricity.” (p. 187) Had the Soviets built a Chernobyl-type nuclear reactor, an explosion or two would not have contributed to disaster prevention. Once when I was discussing the suffering following the USSR collapse with a friend who writes technical documents for the Cuban government, he suddenly blurted out, “The only good thing coming out of the Special Period was that, without the Soviets, Fidel could not build his damned nuclear plant!”

Challenges for Producing Energy: The Uncertain

Between the poles of positive and negative lies a vast array of alternatives mentioned in *Disaster Preparedness* that most are unfamiliar with. There are probably few who know of bagasse, which is leftover sugar cane stalks that have been squeezed for juice. Burning it for fuel might arouse concern because it is not plowed into soil like what should be done for wheat stems and corn stalks. Sugar cane is different because the entire plant is hauled away—it would waste fuel to transport it to squeezing machinery and then haul it back to the farm.

While fuel from bagasse is an overall environmental plus, the same cannot be said for oilseeds such as *Jatropha curcas*. Despite the book suggesting that they might be researched more, they are a dead-end for energy production.

Another energy positive being expanded in Cuba is farms being run entirely on agroecology principles. The book claims that such farms can produce 12 times the energy they consume, which might seem like a lot. Yet, similar findings occur in other countries, notably Sweden. In contrast, at least one author holds out hope of obtaining energy from microalgae, almost certainly another dead end.

Potentially, a very promising source for energy is the use of biogas from biodigesters. Biodigesters break down manure and other biomass to create biogas which is used for tractors or transportation. Leftover solid waste material can be used as a (non-fossil fuel) fertilizer. On the other hand, an energy source which one author lists as viable is highly dubious: “solar cells built with gallium arsenide.” [Compounds with arsenic are cancer-causing](#) and not healthy for humans and other living species.

The word “biomass” is highly charged because it is one of Europe’s “clean, green” energy sources despite the fact that burning wood pellets is leading to deforestation in Estonia and the US. This does not seem to be the case in Cuba, where “biomass” refers to sawdust and weedy marabú trees. It remains important to distinguish positive biomass from highly destructive biomass.

Many other forms of alternative energy could be covered and there is a critical point applying to all of them. Each source of energy must be analyzed separately without ever assuming that if energy does not come from fossil fuels it is therefore useful and safe.

Depending on How You Get It

The three major sources of alternative energy—hydroturbines (dams), solar, and wind—share the characteristic that how positive or negative they are depends on the way they are obtained.

The simplest form of hydro power is the paddle wheel, which probably causes zero environmental damage and produces very little energy. At the other extreme is hydro-electric dams which cross entire rivers and are incredibly destructive towards human cultures and aquatic and terrestrial species. In between are methods such as diverting a portion of the river to harness its power. The book mentions [pico-hydro turbines which affect only a portion of a river](#), generating less than 5kW and are extremely useful for remote areas. They have minimal environmental effects. But if a large number of these turbines were placed together in a river, that would be a different matter. The general rule for water power is that causing less environmental damage means producing less energy.

Many ways to produce energy start with the sun. Cuba uses passive solar techniques, which do not have toxic processes associated with electricity. A *passivehaus* design provides warmth largely via insulation and placement of windows. Extremely important is body heat. This makes a *passivhaus* difficult for Americans, whose homes typically have much more space per person than other countries. But the design could work better in Cuba, where having three generations living together in a smaller space would contribute to heating quite well.

At the negative extreme of solar energy are the land-hungry electricity-generating arrays. In between these poles is low-intensity solar power, also being studied by Cuba.

The vast majority of Cubans heat their water for bathing. Water heaters can depend on solar panels which turn sunlight into electricity. An even better non-electric design would be to use a box with glass doors and a black tank to collect heat, or to use [“flat plate collectors”](#) and then pipe the heated water to an indoor storage tank. As with hydro-power, simpler designs produce fewer problems but generate less energy.

Wind power is highly similar. [Centuries ago, windmills were constructed with materials from the surrounding area](#) and did not rely on or produce toxins. Today’s industrial wind turbines are toxic in every phase of their existence. In the ambiguous category are small wind turbines and wind pumps, both of which Cuba is exploring. What hydro, solar and wind power have in common is that non-destructive forms

exist but produce less energy. The more energy-producing a system is, the more problematic it becomes.

Scuttling the Fetish

Since hydro, solar, and wind power have reputations as “renewable, clean, green” sources of energy, it is necessary to examine them closely. Hydro, solar, and wind power each require destructive extraction of materials such as lithium, cobalt, silver, aluminum, cadmium, indium, gallium, selenium, tellurium, neodymium, and dysprosium. All three lead to mountains of toxic waste that vastly exceed the amount obtained for use. And all require withdrawal of immense amounts of water (a rapidly vanishing substance) during the mining and construction.

[Hydropower](#) also disrupts aquatic species (as well as several terrestrial ones), causes large releases of greenhouse gases (GHGs) from reservoirs, increases mercury poisoning, pushes people out of their homes during construction, intensifies international conflicts, and have killed up to 26,000 people from breakage. Silicon-based solar panels involve an additional list of toxic chemicals that can poison workers during manufacture, gargantuan loss of farm and forest land for installing “arrays” (which rapidly increases over time), and still more land loss for disposal after their [25–30 year life spans](#). [Industrial wind turbines](#) require loss of forest land for roads to haul 160-foot blades to mountain tops, land loss for depositing those mammoth blades after use, and energy-intensive storage capacity when there is no wind.

Hydro, solar, and wind power are definitely *not* renewable, since they all are based on heavy usage of materials that are exhausted following continuous mining. Neither are they “carbon neutral” because all use fossil fuels for extraction of necessary building materials and end-of-life demolition. The most important point is that the issues listed here are a tiny fraction of total problems, which would require a very thick book to enumerate.

Why use the word “fetish” for approaches to hydro, solar, and wind power? A “fetish” can be described as “[a material object regarded with extravagant trust or reverence](#)” These sources of energy have positive characteristics, but nothing like the reverence often bestowed upon them.

Cuba’s approach to alternative energy is quite different. Helen Yaffe wrote two of the major articles in *Disaster Preparedness*. She also put together the 2021 documentary, [Cuba’s Life Task: Combatting Climate Change](#), which includes the following from advisor Orlando Rey Santos:

“One problem today is that you cannot convert the world’s energy matrix, with current consumption levels, from fossil fuels to renewable energies. There are not enough resources for the panels and wind turbines, nor the space for them. There are insufficient resources for all this. If you automatically made all transportation electric tomorrow, you will continue to have the same problems of congestion, parking, highways, heavy consumption of steel and cement.”

Cuba maps out many different outlines for energy in order to focus on those that are the most productive while causing the least damage. A genuine environmental approach requires a Life Cycle Analysis (LCA, also known as cradle-to-grave

accounting) which includes all mining, milling, construction, and transport of materials; the energy-gathering process itself (including environmental disruption); along with after-effects such as continuing environmental damage and disposal of waste. To these must be added social effects such as relocating people, injury and death of those resisting relocation, destruction of sacred sites and disruption of affected cultures.

A “fetish” on a specific energy source denotes tunnel-visioning on its use phase while ignoring preparatory and end-of-life phases and social disruption. While LCAs are often propounded by corporations, they are typically nothing but window-dressing, to be pitched out of window during actual decision-making. With an eternal growth dynamic, capitalism has a built-in tendency to downplay negatives when there is an opportunity to add new energy sources to the mix of fossil fuels.

Is It an Obscene Word?

Cuba has no such internal dynamics forcing it to expand the economy if it can provide better lives for all. The island could be a case study of degrowth economics. Since “degrowth” is shunned as a quasi-obscenity by many who insist that it would cause immeasurable suffering for the world’s poor, it is necessary to state what it would be. The best definition is that Global Economic Degrowth means (a) reduction of unnecessary and destructive production by and for rich countries (and people), (b) which exceeds the (c) growth of production of necessities by and for poor countries (and people).

This might not be as economically difficult as some imagine because ...

1. The rich world spends such gargantuan wealth on that which is useless and deadly, including war toys, chemical poisons, planned obsolescence, creative destruction of goods, insurance, automobile addiction, among a mass of examples; and,
2. Providing the basic necessities of life can often be relatively cheap, such as health care in Cuba being less than 10% of US expenses (with [Cubans having a longer life expectancy and lower infant mortality rate](#)).

Some mischaracterize degrowth, claiming that “Cuba experienced ‘degrowth’ during its ‘Special Period’ and it was horrible.” Wrong! Degrowth did not immiserate Cuba—the US embargo did. US sanctions (or embargo or blockade) of Cuba creates barriers to trade which force absurdly high prices for many goods. One small example: If Cubans need a spare part manufactured in the US, it cannot be merely shipped from the US, but more likely, arrives via Europe. That means its cost will reflect: [manufacture] + [cost of shipping to Europe] + [cost of shipping from Europe to Cuba].

What is amazing is that Cuba has developed so many techniques of medical care and disaster management for hurricanes and climate change, despite its double impoverishment from colonial days and neo-colonial attacks from the US.

Daydreaming

Cuba realizes the responsibility it has to protect its extraordinary biodiversity. Its extensive coral reefs are more resistant to bleaching than most and must be investigated to discover why. They are accompanied by healthy marine systems which

include mangroves and seagrass beds. Its flora and fauna boast 3022 distinct plant species plus dozens of reptiles, amphibians, and bird species that exist only on the island.

For Cuba to implement global environmental protection and degrowth policies it would need to receive financing both to research new techniques and to train the world's poor in how to develop their own ways to live better. Such financial support would include ...

1. Reparations for centuries of colonial plunder;
2. Reparations for the 1961 Bay of Pigs invasion, multiple attacks which killed Cuban citizens, hundreds of attempts on Fidel's life, and decades of slanderous propaganda; and,
3. At least \$1 trillion in reparations for [losses due to the embargo since 1962](#).

Why reparations? It is far more than the fact that Cuba has been harmed intensely by the US. Cuba has a track record proving that it could develop amazing technologies if it were left alone and received the money it deserves.

Like all poor countries, Cuba is forced to employ dubious methods of producing energy in order to survive. It is unacceptable for rich countries to tell poor countries that they must not use energy techniques which have historically been employed to obtain what is necessary for living. It is unconscionable for rich countries to fail to forewarn poor countries that repeating practices which we now know are dangerous will leave horrible legacies for their descendants.

Cuba has acknowledged past misdirections including an economy based on sugar, a belief in the need of humanity to dominate nature, support for the "Green Revolution" with its reliance on toxic chemicals, tobacco in food rations, and the repression of homosexuals. Unless it is sidetracked by advocates of infinite economic growth, its pattern suggests that it will recognize problems with alternative energy and seek to avoid them.

In the video Cuba's Life Task, Orlando Rey also observes that "There must be a change in the way of life, in our aspirations. This is a part of Che Guevara's ideas on the 'new man.' Without forming that new human, it is very difficult to confront the climate issue."

Integration of poor countries into the global market has meant that areas which were once able to feed themselves are now unable to do so. Neo-liberalism forces them to use energy sources that are life-preservers in the short run but are death machines for their descendants. The world must remember that Che's "new man" will not clamor for frivolous luxuries while others starve. For humanity to survive, a global epiphany rejecting consumer capitalism must become a material force in energy production. Was Che only dreaming? If so, then keep that dream alive!

Don Fitz (fitzdon@aol.com) is on the Editorial Board of Green Social Thought, where a version of [this article originally appeared](#). He was the 2016 candidate of the Missouri Green Party for Governor. His articles on politics and the environment have appeared in Monthly Review, Z Magazine, and Green Social Thought, as well as multiple online publications. His book, [Cuban Health Care: The Ongoing Revolution](#), has been available since June 2020. Thoughts from Stan Cox and John Som de Cerff were very helpful for technical aspects of this review.

Schmo Munchkin v. Ida

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Ida: Hello, Schmo

Munchkin:

I'm the most powerful politician in the most powerful deliberative body in the most powerful country in the world and who the hell are you?

Ida:

Who the hell do you think I am, Mr. Muthafrakkker Fossil Fuel-Big Pharma-errand boy?

I'm Ida, Sister of Sandy, Daughter of Katrina and Alcohol, Geritol, protocol puppets like you don't impress me...

Munchkin:

What?! How'd you manage to get in here anyway?

Get out now, or I'm calling the Capitol Police...

Ida: Capitol Police? You remind me of another reason I'm visiting 16 years to the day...All your crowing about body-armored, bear spray-bearing, feeble-minded men "storming" Capitalist Hill January 6 insulted us!

Storms are more complex and simple than bunches of wild Boer police/soldiers in lynch mob mode...

We're traumatized survivors of corporate-caused climate catastrophe That's why we kill...What's your excuse, Schmo?

Munchkin:

Why, you young cunt, you! You don't come to Capitalist Hill and talk to a powerful man like me like that! Get out! Get out now, before I have the FBI frame you, ICE detain you and the CIA assassinate you before can say clean coal!

Ida:

Your framers, detainers, assassins, bombs, missiles, drones, and submarines don't frighten me. I knocked down 8 power lines and washed out 100 police cars on my way here...

Munchkin:

You blasphemous bitch how dare you speak to a U.S. Senator like this! I'll convene a bipartisan Senate Sub-Committee and get to the bottom of your bitchy behavior! Then I'll plant stories in the Times, the Post, on FOX I'll ruin your reputation! Why, your name'll be mud by morning's end!

Ida:

Enough with the impotent threats enough with comedy that bombs and kills... fossil fool!
Enough with corny failed state slogans and cruel commands: "Build back better!" "Prepare for a month without power;" while you bomb, sanction and oversee \$elections of bloodthirsty thugs across the globe!

Munchkin:

Police, police...we have a credible crazy an Eco-Identity-Extremist-Terrorist threat... get up here ASAP now!

Ida:

Quite the drama queen, heh, coal baron-Karen?
A few months ago you and your corporate pay-masters could conceal carnage caused by blowing heads off mountains; ejaculating fracking fluid into groundwaters; and pumping pig shit into ponds near peoples' homes...

Munchkin: The American people aren't interested in your hysterical horse-faced lesbian commie rant! They have the Super Bowl; NBA Finals; boxing; and superstar celebrities to worship! They have apple-orange GOAT debates! They have twenty-two types of toothpastes and toilet tissues to think about! And, as well Ms Wet Thing, they get to vote every 2-4 years...

Ida:

Senator Sleaze, you and your fossil fuel puppeteers have royally f'd this planet up! And now you're scheming Space escapes; now you're hunting other planets to plunder! Your multibillionaire bosses better slow their roll maybe take the time to snort a line or two of the Green New Deal...

Munchkin: Why, you wind-bagging wench, how many times must I tell you... you don't talk to a U.S. Senator like that?!

Ida: Gulf and east coast homes look like Palestinian apartment buildings struck by water-filled apartheid state missiles...
And the roads are rivers...

Munchkin: I knew it...you're an anti-Semite an anti-Semitic storm!!

Ida: PLEASE, Your Slime-e-Ness, we're dyed in the wool internationalists. That's why we're applying 'Super Storm Sanctions' to the U.S. ...bet you know a thing or two about how sanctions work: No break from Heartbreak...

Hey, maybe 'the American people' will rise like rivers and sweep your scurvy asses out to sea? Maybe they'll spare the world eternal grief?

Munchkin: Out!!!!

Ida: Oh, I'll be back...No...my lil' Sistars Serena and Simone; my lil' brothers LeBron and Shaq will soon make landfall, serving, flipping, twisting, slamming and drenching this slow motion Disaster you call capitalism!

Munchkin: The Capitol Police are on their way...

Ida: Tell them to save their energy for bear spray-baton boys. I'm off to the War House to see the other Schmo! From there I'll sweep over the White Supreme Court checking Strong-arm Williams'/Thom-ass Clarence's Bassackwards Tribe Tom Talks...

Raymond Nat Turner is Black Agenda Report's poet in residence and an accomplished performing artist. You can find much more of his work at upsurgejazz.com

CODE RED!!

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Calling all street heat shoe leather legislators
Calling all pavement policymakers bored by the bigtop: clean coal
clowns; fossil fools; net zero acrobats; carbon
jugglers...Bored by greasy-thumbbed grifters and jingoist
gangsters; Bored by junk metal-chested generals disguised
as donkeys inside elephants Tethered to tits on Wall Street's
bull... Blocking! Stalling! Gaslighting! Waging war by other names...

Calling all street heat shoe leather legislators
Calling all pavement policymakers bored by the bigtop: tired of 2/4
Dancers dancing the Limbo from bended knees;
Tired of them spinning spineless legislation swaddled in
rectangular rags reaching across their arid aisle and
Externalizing excrement. Leaving dung-splattered streets to
3 monkeys who See No Oil; Hear No Coal; Speak of No Gas as evil...

Calling all street heat shoe leather legislators
Calling all pavement policymakers... Who'll stop
the circus from sullyng our names with climate
crime? Who'll say their names their Wall Street
gang names reconnecting them to climate crimes?
Who'll say Superstorm Chevron?
Nor' easter Exxon; Tsunami Shell?
And who'll say Blackened bird BP?

Calling all street heat shoe leather legislators
Calling all pavement policymakers who may or
may not remember the Arab Spring; Remember Occupy
lingo "1%"/"99%." Remember knitted brows; Remember
putting forehead to problems
created by person Hoods aka corporate kings and queens...

Calling all street heat shoe leather legislators
Calling all pavement policymakers recall rubber
bullet, plastic cuff, bloody, broken bone, stolen eyeball-
tooth trauma...Recall draconian sentences required to
arrest killer cops; wrench slavers statues from pedestals;
Rechristen schools, streets, parks, plazas, teams; Retire
Unca Ben, Aunt Jemima with stars and bars at NASCAR

Calling all street heat shoe leather legislators
and scholars
Calling all pavement policymakers and professors...
Study resistance. Major in mass action. Your gait, your
posture's perfect like ours once were
Matriculate 2020-like. And defend dissertations entitled: "Fossil Fuels,
Force and Deception of The Corporate State
University Of The Streets..."

*Raymond Nat Turner is Black Agenda Report's poet in residence and an accomplished
performing artist. You can find much more of his work at upsurgejazz.com*

Don't Forget George W. Bush Was A War Criminal

PHILIP REISS

I begin with William Blum's pertinent observation: "How Bush and his junta succeeded in deflecting America's anger from bin Laden to Saddam Hussein is one of the great public relations conjuring tricks of history." Informed people know Saddam Hussein didn't plan or facilitate the September 11, 2001 attacks on Manhattan's Twin Towers and the Pentagon building in Washington DC.

Prior to Bush's call for military action against Iraq, Hans Blix, head of the United Nations Monitoring Verification and Inspection Commission, was in Iraq from March 2000 to June 2003. To that date Blix reported his inspectors hadn't discovered weapons of mass destruction. He thought they would complete their search in three months and believed they wouldn't find weapons the Bush administration claimed they were there. However, the Bush administration didn't want to wait for additional information Blix would gather, as it would negate their claim.

Not inclined to wait for Blix to complete his search, which was likely to prove Bush was misleading the American public, he ordered Secretary of State Colin Powell to give a speech at the United Nations. Powell made claims that challenged and contradicted the Blix commission's findings. Powell's presentation was exaggerated distortions based on the premise America had no time to wait for Blix to finish his commission's work.

Thus, Powell's presentation permitted the Bush administration, Great Britain's Tony Blair, and most Americans to believe that military action against Saddam's Iraq had to be initiated immediately. This is a classic case of the ignorant supporting a rush to judgment. However, before the decade was over, Powell belatedly owned up to his deceit. He was embarrassed he had been made to look like a fool, and was used by Bush who desired to look like a decisive 'great' president. George H. W. Bush had been accused of being indecisive, "wishy washy," etc. Maybe George W. Bush was subconsciously competing with his father.

One estimate, some think too low, is that 250,000 Iraqis lost their lives. Estimates of American military deaths are 6,000 with close to 16,000 wounded. Many wounded Americans had arms and legs blown off or shattered. Hundreds needed plastic surgery on wounds to their faces. It's ironic that most troops believed they were doing their patriotic duty. Maybe, I hope, some now realize they were misled, actually lied to, regarding whose interest they were serving.

The war on Iraq received support from most Senators as well. The then US Senators Joe Biden and Hillary Clinton, as well as Chuck Schumer, the late John McCain, Pennsylvania's Rick Santorum and Arlen Specter, Nevada's Harry Reid, and Mitch McConnell of KY were among the 77 senators who supported the war. Among the 23 Senators opposing Bush's war were Jon Corzine of New Jersey, Robert Byrd of WV, Barbara Boxer of CA, Russell Feingold of WI, and Richard Durbin of Illinois.

In the House, 296 representatives voted for the war; only 133 voted against it. Bernie Sanders, then in the House, voted against it, as did Pennsylvania's Robert Brady, William Coyne, Mike Doyle, and Chaka Fattah, California's Barbara Lee, Cynthia McKinney, Gary Condit, Lois Capps and Nancy Pelosi, Ohio's Marcy Kaptur and Dennis Kucinich and New York's Louise Slaughter, Jose Serrano, Major Owens, Charles Rangel, Jerrold Nadler and Maurice Hinchey.

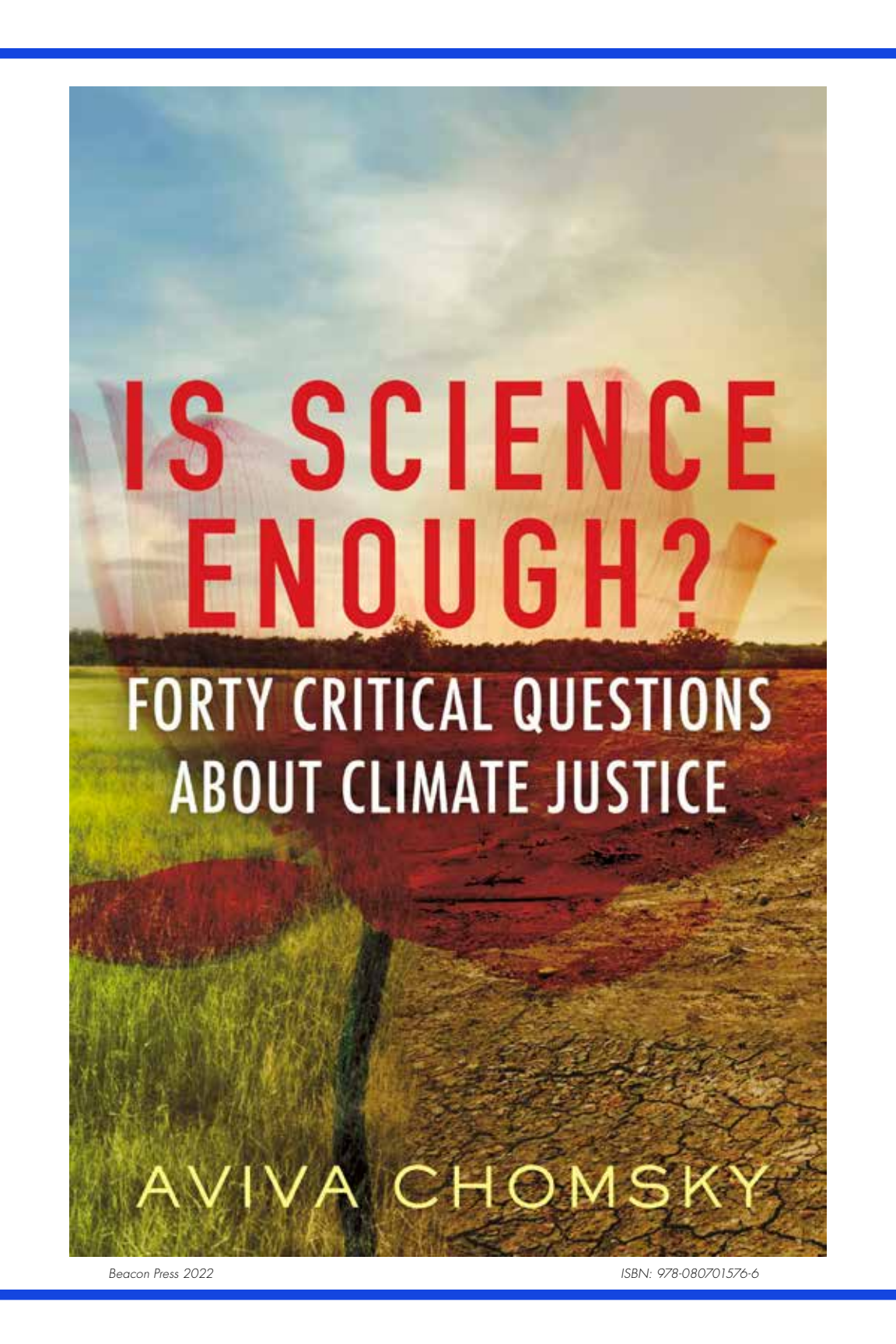
The Bush administration engaged in torture of detainees, using various methods including the use of "waterboarding," a procedure by which a prisoner is made to believe that she is about to be drowned. The administration refused to call these by their proper name. Instead they employed the obscurantist bureaucratic term "enhanced interrogation techniques." But, what would Americans think if an adversary used similar torture techniques or procedures on captured US personnel? Would there be any doubt that these would instantly be labeled as torture and treated as criminal acts accompanied with strong demands to bring those responsible to account for their actions. Alas, wars generate hypocrisy and those who wage them seek to obscure their role in the brutalities they unleash.

Today few Americans remember the incident when Bush while visiting Iraq and giving a statement to an Iraqi audience, was called a liar by an Iraqi in the audience who proceeded to throw his shoes at him. Bush quickly ducked. Unfortunately, hundreds of thousands of Iraqis couldn't duck and get out of the way of thousands of bombs that Bush dropped on them that destroyed their country and took the lives of tens of thousands unnecessarily.

How could any reasonable American approve of what the US has done to Iraq? The Iraqi people had done us no harm and were not responsible for what happened on September 11, 2001. Today, many Americans consider the war on Iraq a distant memory. That is a way of empire: it wages bloody interventions abroad while distracting the public with the latest crisis de jour, guaranteeing impunity for the crimes of empire.

Howard Zinn, the late radical historian, once penned the following words that every American ought to be reminded of: "There is no flag large enough to cover the shame of killing innocent people."

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The background of the book cover is a composite image. The top half shows a cloudy sky with a rainbow. The bottom half shows a landscape with a green field on the left and a dry, cracked, brown field on the right, separated by a dark, winding path. The title is overlaid on the sky, and the subtitle is overlaid on the landscape.

IS SCIENCE ENOUGH?

FORTY CRITICAL QUESTIONS
ABOUT CLIMATE JUSTICE

AVIVA CHOMSKY